

NOTES TO MY KIDS (AND GRANDKIDS)

On My Personal Exploration of the

LAWS OF GOD'S LOVE

Volume 2: The Intentional Journey of the Heart

How to Actually Operate in the Laws of the Spirit

Study and Reflections of a Dad and Granddaddy

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The Larger Story: Where This Volume Sits

I am putting this chapter at the front of Vol 2 for the same reason I put *What We Are Being Formed For* at the front of Vol 1. Everything that follows in this volume — the diagnostic work, the Tool Map, the clearing protocols, the hearing development, the container discipline, the community amplification — can be read in two completely different ways, and the difference is decided here.

The Bible is one Story

Jesus, on the road to Emmaus, “beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself” (Luke 24:27, ESV). The point is structural. The Old Testament is not a collection of stories. The New Testament is not a collection of moral teachings. From Genesis to Revelation, the Bible is one Story — the Larger Story, John Eldredge and Brent Curtis named it in *The Sacred Romance* — that begins in the garden and ends at the wedding feast of the Lamb (Rev. 19:7–9), with the cosmos under conflict in between and the King of glory at the center of every act.

The Story has the form of every Story the human heart has ever recognized as true: a beauty made, a betrayal, a long exile, a hero who comes and gives himself for the beloved, an enemy defeated, a wedding. C. S. Lewis named this in his term “the true myth” — that the deepest pattern of human storytelling is true because the cosmos is itself a Story, and the Author wrote himself into it. The Bible is not one mythological story among many. It is the Story that all the others were echoing.

What this matters for Vol 2: the participant doing the work this volume describes is not first a patient receiving treatment. The participant is first a character in this Story. The wounds being cleared, the sins being confessed, the idols being dethroned, the lies being broken, the hearing being developed, the community being formed — all of this is happening inside the Larger Story, and the participant’s place in it is real.

Four moves of the Story

The Story has four moves. Each is essential to understanding why Vol 2’s work is the kind of work it is.

Creation. “In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth” (Gen. 1:1, ESV). Everything came from love, and everything was good. Man and woman were made in God’s image (Gen. 1:27), placed in a garden, given dominion, designed for communion with God and one another. The original setting is not neutral; it is glory. Whatever the participant has experienced of beauty, longing, intimacy, vocation, friendship — these are echoes of what we were made for in the original Story.

Fall. The Enemy entered the Story as a serpent in the garden (Gen. 3) and proposed a lie that the participant, in some form, has heard her whole life: God is holding out on you, the rules are restrictions on your freedom, you can be like God yourself if you take what was forbidden. Man and woman believed it, and the world broke. The ground was cursed, communion with God was severed, the woman bore children in sorrow, the man worked the ground in sweat, and death entered (Gen. 3:14–19). But in the middle of the curse, God spoke a promise to the serpent: “I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel” (Gen. 3:15, ESV). The first promise of the Seed who would undo what was done.

Redemption. The whole of the Old Testament tells the story of God preparing the world for the coming of that Seed: Abraham called out, Israel formed, the law given, the prophets sent, the kingdom established, the exile suffered, the longing maintained for the One who would come. Then

the Word became flesh and dwelt among us (John 1:14). Jesus lived, taught the kingdom, healed, suffered, died on the cross to bear the curse that had broken the world, and rose on the third day. The serpent's head was crushed at Calvary (Col. 2:15; Heb. 2:14). The Story's deepest turn happened there — the place where what looked like the Enemy's triumph was actually his defeat. The participant doing the work this volume describes is doing it because Christ has done that work first. Every wound that can be healed, every sin that can be forgiven, every idol that can be dethroned, every lie that can be broken — all of this is possible because of what happened on a particular Friday in a particular garden outside a particular city. This work is downstream of the cross.

Consummation. The Story is not over. The Church is the Bride being prepared (Eph. 5:25–27); the Spirit is given as a deposit (Eph. 1:13–14); the Enemy is still at work, though he is a defeated foe; the participant is being formed for the coming wedding (Rev. 19:7–9), the new heaven and new earth (Rev. 21:1–4), the City where there is no more crying or pain or death. The Story is moving toward its final scene. Every disciple is in the chapter just before the final chapter, and the final chapter is glory.

What this means for the work below

The participant doing the work this volume describes is doing it inside this Story. That changes everything operationally.

The wounds the participant is clearing are real wounds done by real characters inside the war, which are the second through fourth moves of the Story. The Enemy is not a metaphor; he is the serpent of Genesis 3, the accuser of Revelation 12:10, the lion seeking whom he may devour (1 Pet. 5:8). The Cross is not a doctrinal proposition; it is the moment in the Story when the curse was actually broken. The Spirit's work in the participant's heart is not a therapeutic technique; it is the Spirit of the Risen Christ applying the finished work of the Cross to the specific places in the participant where the curse still has its grip.

The Romance is real. The participant's deepest longing — for beauty, for intimacy with God, for a love that does not fail, for a place she belongs — is the heart's response to being made for the Bridegroom. The Sacred Romance, Eldredge and Curtis called it. The participant's heart is not deceived by its longing; it is being drawn by the One who put the longing there. “He has put eternity into man's heart” (Eccl. 3:11, ESV).

The Adventure is real. The participant has a part in the Story. Eph. 2:10 (ESV): “We are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them.” The good works prepared beforehand are not generic moral acts; they are specific to the participant, prepared for her in the Story, and she walks in them as a particular character with a particular role. The participant's vocation is not the application of general principles; it is the playing of a particular part in a particular act of a particular Story.

The war is real. “We do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places” (Eph. 6:12, ESV). The clearing work in this volume is also warfare work. The lies the participant is breaking, the contracts she is renouncing, the false-self verdicts she is dismantling — these are battlegrounds the Enemy has occupied, and reclaiming them is real territory taken back. This is named more fully in V2.Exp2B (the Adversary's Role), but it should be felt as the texture of every chapter of this volume.

What this is not

This framing is not a license for romantic exaggeration, spiritual-warfare theatricality, or therapeutic-clearing dressed up in mythic language. The Bridge from Knowing to Doing (the next chapter) names the gap between intellectual assent and lived participation that this volume exists to address — that gap is structural and real, and the work to address it has to be specific and disciplined. The Story-framing this chapter names is not a substitute for the diagnostic care, the tool discernment, the Formation Companion competency, the container discipline, the doctrinal frame on hearing, or the wound/sin distinction that the rest of Vol 2 develops. The Story-framing is the orientation that makes those disciplines what they are.

Without this framing, the rest of Vol 2 reads as protocol. With it, the same content is participation in the Story — apprenticeship in the way of Christ, who is himself the protagonist of the Story the participant is in. This is the orientation Vol 2 assumes. Without it, the diagnostic and operational work below drifts into a clinical-clearing system. With it, the same work is the disciple's role in the Larger Story.

Introduction: The Bridge from Knowing to Doing

Everything that follows in this volume is operationally what Dallas Willard (and the broader formation tradition) call the Means: the diagnostic and tool-application practices by which a disciple is formed for life in the kingdom of God, present-tense now (Mark 1:15; Luke 17:21; Rom. 14:17). Vision and Intention belong to Vol 1's framing chapter; this volume assumes both are in place. What this means practically: the work described here is the apprentice's work, not the patient's. The participant is being formed for kingdom-life (Matt. 11:28–30; Luke 6:40), not merely cleared so she can resume the life she was already trying to live. Without that horizon, the tools and protocols in this volume drift into a sophisticated sin-and-wound management system; with it, the same content becomes apprenticeship in the way of Christ.

There is a moment that every serious student of the spiritual life eventually reaches, and it is not a comfortable one. It is the moment when you realize that knowing a spiritual law is not the same as living in it.

I have been working on Volume 1 for over two decades. The explorations there — the logical relationships, the if-then structures, the causal laws, the structural maps of faith and hope and love and wisdom — are real. I believe them. I can state them with reasonable precision and ground them in scripture. And yet I have spent long stretches of my life where the channel was functionally closed, where I was hearing almost nothing, where the Word was coming in but producing very little fruit. The laws were true. My experience did not match. That gap is what this volume is about.

The governing premise of Volume 2 is simple: the laws discovered in Volume 1 are operational for a person whose channel is open, whose heart soil is in good condition, and whose community is functioning as designed. Most of us, most of the time, are not in that state. Not because we are bad people or weak believers, but because life does damage, and the damage accumulates, and unaddressed damage blocks hearing just as surely as a physical obstruction blocks a pipe.

I want to add one dimension to this framing that Eldredge consistently presses and that I think is simply true: the accumulation of damage is not merely the unfortunate result of a fallen world. The enemy actively works to keep those wounds unhealed and the agreements they produce firmly in place — because a believer who cannot hear is a believer who cannot act. The therapeutic work in Part II of this volume is also, therefore, spiritual warfare work. Clearing a grief knot or breaking a lie is not just emotional hygiene; it is reclaiming ground. That framing changes how you approach the tools.

Volume 2 is about getting the pipe clear and keeping it that way.



This is organized into three parts. Part I is diagnostic — what are the conditions that block hearing and faith? Part II is therapeutic — what tools, processes, and encounters with the Holy Spirit clear those blockages? Part III is developmental — what practices and community structures sustain and deepen the channel once it has been cleared?

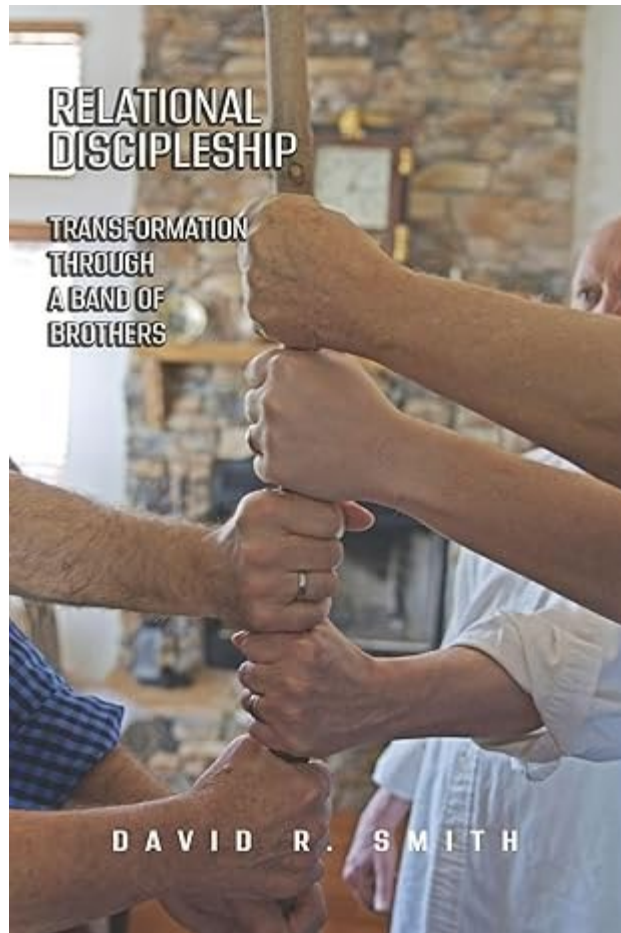
Each exploration follows the same format as Volume 1: a clear causal law stated up front, scripture grounding, connection to the Volume 1 laws it enables or expresses, and the practical process that makes it experiential rather than merely conceptual. I stand on Principle 3 from Volume 1: these laws are knowable in all three worlds — spirit, mind, and body. If I only know them in my head, I have not yet known them.

A word about the tools and processes described in Part II. Many of them came to me through other people — Leanne Payne and Rita Bennett in inner healing, the Grief Recovery Handbook, Transformation Prayer Ministry, Wild at Heart, and the Band of Brothers work I have done with men over many years. This includes many secular sources. I am not their originator; I am a practitioner who has seen them work. These processes are tested, many times in my life and the men I have been privileged to work with. Where I can, I point you to the source. What I am claiming is not that I invented the tools but that I have discovered, through experience, how they connect to the laws in Volume 1. That connection — between the practical tools and the underlying spiritual laws — is my contribution to the discussion.

Also, as I continue to edit and update this particular volume, I am so struck by the man-centric view presented, but that is my real experience. I’m not talking about things that I haven’t experienced, and mixed gender groups are rare in my personal experience, just because I have been focused on men’s work. I have been in couples’ Bible studies pretty much all these years, but those were not intentional journeys of the heart. We had no model to tell us differently. My hope and desire is that major updates to this discussion will be done by women who have done the work, lived the life, internalized the Word, and are ready to share what God has given them. I’m looking forward to that.

Before I dive in, let me acknowledge two debts that deserve fuller recognition than a passing mention.

The first is to Dave Smith. Dave and I have walked through much of the experiential work described in this volume together. We have been a Band of Brothers for many years, using protocols derived from multiple sources and adapting what we could align faithfully with scripture. Dave has recently published a book documenting some of the processes we worked with: “Relational Discipleship: Transformation Through a Band of Brothers” (Dorrance Publishing). I recommend it without reservation to anyone who wants to follow the Band of Brothers trail more fully. His book is an important supplement to the discussion here.



Here is the link to the publisher of Dave's book:

<https://bookstore.dorrancepublishing.com/products/relational-discipleship>

I highly recommend getting to know this book and Dave.

The second is John Eldredge. His books, particularly *Wild at Heart* (2001) and *Waking the Dead* (2003), gave Dave and me scriptural grounding and encouragement at several critical points in the development of this work. Eldredge is working in a related field: the recovery of the heart's design, the clearing of the wounds that suppress it, and the larger spiritual battle in which that recovery takes place. Where my framework tends toward the analytical and systematic, Eldredge's tends toward the narrative and experiential. Both orientations are needed. My debt to him is not just for specific ideas, it is for the confidence that the interior work I was finding in men's lives had scriptural roots and was being discovered by others in different contexts.

I want to be clear about what I am claiming when I reference Eldredge's work in what follows. I am not claiming that Eldredge is the source of the laws I am proposing. The laws are drawn from scripture and confirmed through experience. Eldredge's contribution is to have named certain dynamics in the masculine heart: the wound, the false self, the three core desires, and the enemy's strategy against the heart with a clarity and accessibility that I have found repeatedly useful in both my own interior work and in working with other men. Where I reference him, I am saying: if you want more on this dynamic, and want it in a form that is grounded, accessible, and personally challenging, read Eldredge. He will get you there a different way than I will, and that is worth something.

A Note on the Registry and Governance. The explorations in this volume are encoded in vol2-claims.yml, with confidence ratings and dependencies on Volume 1 claims explicitly tracked. Most of the claims in this volume are Tier 2 working claims (Reasonably Inferred confidence) under the Volume 6 governance, which is appropriate for material that is both genuinely practical and genuinely open to refinement as the testing program in Volume 4 and the Followship of the Heart refines the processes and returns results. The Heart Soil diagnostic and the Sin Blockage law are the Tier 1 anchor claims in this volume; the rest move by the normal governance rhythm of contribution, comment, and Council consent.

Taxonomy Key: How This Volume Classifies Its Explorations

Volume 2 builds on the Structural and Operational law types from Volume 1 and adds three new categories. This is the complete taxonomy for this volume, showing how each type relates to the investigations in Volumes 1 and 3.

Inherited: Structural and Operational Laws

The full foundation for this taxonomy — including the distinction between Structural Laws (what exists and how it is organized) and Operational Laws (what causes what) — is laid in Volume 1's Taxonomy Key and in the Intro's "A Note on Two Kinds of Laws"; readers new to this volume should start there.

Diagnostic Laws (New in Vol 2)

A Diagnostic Law refers to a condition that prevents the Vol 1 operational laws from functioning properly. The Heart Soil exploration is an example of a Diagnostic Law: it identifies the internal conditions that hinder the Word → Hearing → Faith chain from yielding fruit. Diagnostic Laws do not explain how things work when the channel is open — instead, they describe what it looks like when it is blocked and why. They serve as the clinical category: they identify the presenting condition and point toward the appropriate clearing tool.

Tool-Application Laws (New in Vol 2)

A Tool-Application Law explains how a particular clearing tool corresponds to a specific blockage type. These laws focus not directly on spiritual dynamics but on the proper preparation for the Spirit to work. The Tool Map exploration serves as the main Tool-Application Law in this volume. The key principle is that using a tool on the wrong type of blockage won't produce a release and might cause additional harm. Recognizing the type of blockage before choosing a tool is a skill that requires expertise from the Vol 1 Wisdom cluster.

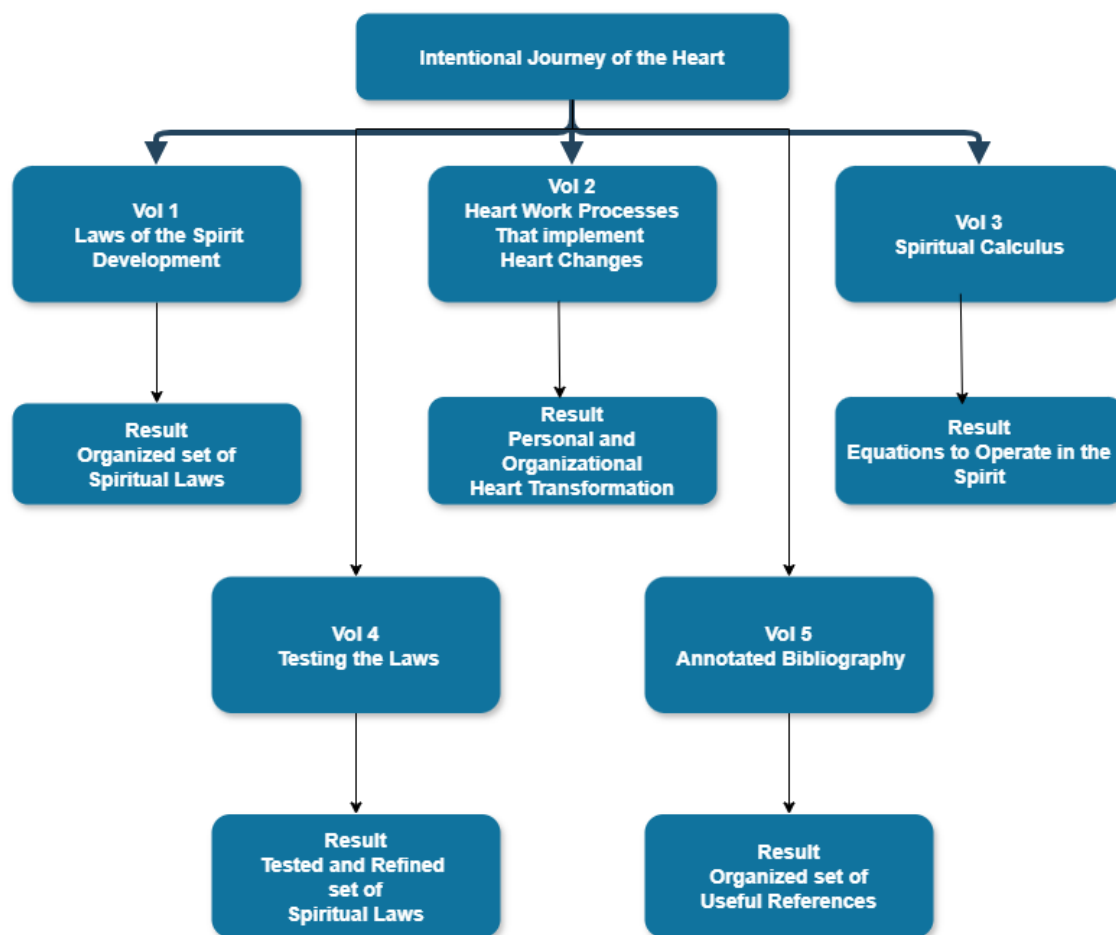
Developmental Laws (New in Vol 2)

A Developmental Law explains how the capacity for the spiritual life develops over time through deliberate practice. These laws are neither structural nor diagnostic; they describe movement and growth. The Affective Taxonomy mapping serves as the main framework for Developmental Laws in this volume: the five-level progression (Receiving → Responding → Valuing → Organization → Characterization) illustrates not just a state but a direction of development. Developmental Laws address the key question: once the channel is clear and the soil is ready, how does life in the Spirit deepen?

Foundational Practice

A Foundational Practice is not a law in the same sense as the other types in this volume; it is a sustained pattern of attention that the historic Christian tradition has practiced as a means of grace. The Foundational Practice type names what sits beneath the diagnostic, tool-application, and developmental work this volume catalogs — the soil-conditioning a soul does over years so that, when a blockage arrives or a hearing matures, there is a soul present to do the work. V2.ExpoB (The Contemplative Substrate) is the first entry of this type and names four practices (fixed-hour prayer, lectio divina, silent waiting, vigilantia cordis) that the rest of this volume's catalog assumes. The substrate is not parallel to the Diagnostic / Tool-Application / Developmental tier; it sits beneath it. A Companion who has not practiced what sits beneath cannot reliably operate what sits above. These are discussed in the Formation Companion discussion in Vol 5.

How This Taxonomy Connects to Volumes 1 and 3



Volume 1's structural and operational laws explain how things work when the channel functions. Volume 2's diagnostic, tool-application, and developmental laws explain what to do when the channel isn't working and how to develop it over time once it does. Volume 3 will reframe both sets: it considers the Vol 1 laws as the landscape, while the Vol 2 conditions are seen as local minima (emotional knots) and trajectory variables (developmental laws) within that landscape. The Affective

Taxonomy introduced in Vol 2 becomes a measurement protocol in Vol 3 — the most manageable current method I know of for operationalizing spiritual distance.

VOL 1 CONNECTION: The main premise of this entire volume — that the Vol 1 laws are valid but obscured — requires a clear understanding of the Vol 1 laws first. If you haven't worked through Vol 1's explorations, the diagnostic framework here will be less clear than it should be. Specifically, the Heart Soil diagnostic (Exp. 1) depends on familiarity with the Word → Hearing → Faith operational law (Vol 1, Exp. 1) and the nested person structure (Vol 1, Exp. 2).

VOL 3 CONNECTION: Volume 3 employs the Affective Taxonomy introduced in this volume as its main measurement protocol for spiritual distance. The five-level progression serves as a tool for translating the abstract concept of "spiritual distance" into observable behavioral indicators. Volume 3's exploration of this connection asks: Can Affective Taxonomy levels be linked with REVEAL type stages across a congregation? That research question relies on the framework from Volume 2 as its foundation.

How the Formation Documents Connect to This Volume

Volume 2 (this volume) is the central focus of the Formation Documents' concerns. Everything in the diagnostic, therapeutic, and developmental explorations here directly corresponds to HFT's Affective Taxonomy, SST's soul taxonomy, or MSFIG's integrated model. The Formation Documents stem from the same investigation — they are the academic expression of what this volume is exploring pastorally. While this volume asks what blocks the channel and how to clear it, HFT and MSFIG inquire what progressive opening looks like from within, and how we can recognize it. Where this volume asks how the hearing faculty develops, SST's soul and spirit taxonomies provide the developmental framework. Reading them together is like viewing two sides of the same map.

I mention the REVEAL study progression because it identified a staged model of spiritual formation. However, I have found the NCD approach to individual, small-group, and church-wide development much more helpful for both understanding and application. I have used their assessment tools for both individual and small-group feedback. My church has not adopted the church-wide tools, but I think they should, and I think they would find the feedback helpful. So, what follows is a mix of these two approaches that have been successful across multiple churches and denominations. I think the Affective Taxonomy approach to understanding this progression is more grounded and helpful, but it would certainly be harder to implement.

For any model, the reality of this journey is that it is not linear. Anyone on such an intentional journey will recognize that. The phrase "two steps forward and one step back" captures the idea. The core issue is, which way are you pointing at any given time? The formation documents discuss the role of suffering in this non-linear path in some detail. There are mountain tops and deep valleys on the journey. Faith and hope are what keep us focused in the right direction.

There is a picture that the Lord showed me many years ago that is relevant to what follows. I saw my life, my heart, as an L-shaped pipe. The top was receiving God's love for me and the world. The output flowed into a dry, dusty world, thirsty for his love. My output was just a trickle. I had too many barnacles interfering with the flow, slowing it down until only a little could get through. I understood that working out your salvation with fear and trembling might mean for me: to clear out the barnacles so his love can flow more and more. The following discussion on how heart knots interfere with hearing and obeying God puts more details on that thought.

PART I

Diagnosis: Why the Channel Gets Blocked

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION O — TOOL IMPORT DISCIPLINE (OPERATING GROUND)

Exploration O: The Christian Companion's Framework — Tool Import Discipline

Why an Exploration O

Many tools in this volume came from somewhere outside the Christian formation tradition before it entered our practice. The Grief Recovery Handbook came from secular grief work. TPM came from a particular evangelical lineage that had its own assumptions. Voice Dialogue came from depth psychology. Psychodrama came from Moreno. The Bilgere carpet-work recipe came from Mindell's Process-Oriented Psychology, which came from Jungian analytics. The 7×7 mortality contemplation came from existential-philosophy lineages with no Christian commitments at all. PROAPT was the closest to a native-Christian tool, and even it borrowed structural moves from Ignatian and Benedictine reading practice.

This is not a problem unless it is treated as one and then ignored. The problem is the opposite — pretending that any of these tools is a neutral instrument, an empty pipe through which Christian content can be poured without the pipe shaping what flows through it. The pipe has a shape. The shape was set by people who answered the questions "What is a person? What is wrong with us? What heals us? Whose work is it?" in particular ways. Those answers ride along with the tool, often invisibly, and they shape what the participant absorbs from experiencing the tool, even when the surface content is impeccably Christian.

The discipline of this Exploration is to bring the Christian framework explicitly to every tool: to name what aligns with the gospel, to adapt what does not, and to refuse what cannot be adapted without becoming something else. Powlison's three-step grid *frame/pattern/response* is the operational form of this work that I have found most clarifying, and the Phase 2 program's practitioner-level treatment of each tool applies the grid in detail. The grid asks three questions in sequence for each imported tool: *What secular frame was the tool developed under? What operational pattern does the tool actually deploy in practice? What is the right Christian response — receive, adapt, or refuse?*

The Worked Example: Mortality-Contemplation Practices

I want to give one worked example in this volume, because the discipline is hard to grasp in the abstract. The mortality-contemplation practices the corpus deploys (the *memento mori* tradition from monastic sources; Heidegger's *Sein-zum-Tode* as it filtered into the Mankind Project's death-bed visualization; the 7×7 mortality contemplation Dmitri Bilgere developed; and beneath them, Heidegger's philosophical project of using finite mortality as the horizon against which authenticity is recovered) all share an operational form: the participant contemplates their own death in order to recover a clearer sense of what their life is actually for.

The operational force was real for me when I first experienced it and again as I led others through the process. People who do this work in a serious way come out of it with their priorities re-sorted, their pretenses thinned, their commitments clearer. The mechanism works. But the Heideggerian frame under which the practice was developed treats the participant's finite horizon as the ultimate

reference point — death is the limit against which authenticity is gauged, and there is nothing beyond it that orders the meaning. That frame is not neutral. It quietly substitutes the participant's death for the master's return as the eschatological horizon under which the participant's life is to be ordered.

The Companion's work, when receiving this practice into Christian formation, is to re-frame it under an explicitly eschatological horizon: not death-as-final-limit but death-as-threshold-to-judgment, *to the master's return* (Luke 12:35–40), *to the judgment seat of Christ* (2 Cor 5:10), *to the day God has appointed* (Acts 17:31). The operational force of the contemplation is preserved; the source-tradition's metaphysical horizon is set aside; the reframing is the Formation Companion's work rather than the participant's; the participant receives the practice already reframed. That is what V2.Expo looks like at protocol depth for one tool. The Phase 2 entry on A15 (7×7 Process) and the Vol 5 Companion paper give the full operational treatment.

The Discipline in Brief

Phase 2 of the tool-import program — the practitioner-level treatment of each imported tool in Vol 5 — operates under this discipline throughout. Every tool entry names its source lineage, identifies what in the source frame requires adaptation or refusal, and states what the operational pattern looks like once it has been brought under the gospel framework. The Companion who deploys a tool without this discipline quietly smuggles its source framework into the formation work, with the participant absorbing the imported anthropology along with the imported technique. The Christian framework is the operating ground of the volume; every subsequent Exploration assumes it.

Proposed Law (Tool Import Discipline): Tools imported from secular originals into Christian formation work are not neutral instruments; they carry the anthropology, epistemology, and account of agency embedded in their source frameworks. The Formation Companion brings the Christian framework to every tool — naming what aligns with the gospel, adapting what does not, and refusing what cannot be adapted. The Powlison three-step grid (frame / pattern / response) is the operational discipline that enacts this work. Tools deployed without this discipline quietly smuggle their source frameworks into Christian formation, with the participant absorbing the imported anthropology along with the imported technique.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *Operational pattern; existing canonical statement in the Vol 5 Powlison/Trentham material. The V2-level placement is an operational restatement of the Vol 5 material, not a new theological move. The worked-example paragraph (eschatological framing of mortality-adjacent practices) is somewhat lower confidence (Clearly Taught) than the broader tool-import discipline, but the framing is operationally settled across the corpus's mortality-adjacent material.*

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 1 — DIAGNOSTIC LAW

First Exploration: The Heart Soil — A Diagnostic Map



Why the Sower Parable Is Not Just About Evangelism

Most of the time when we read the parable of the Sower, we read it as a description of four kinds of people — the hardened unbeliever, the enthusiastic but shallow convert, the distracted churchgoer, and the genuine disciple. That reading is not wrong. But it is incomplete, and the incompleteness costs us something important.

The more searching reading is this: the four soil types describe four conditions of my own heart at any given moment — not four categories of people, but four regions of a person's interior landscape. Parts of my heart are good soil. Parts are thorny. Parts are rocky. And parts — if I am honest — are still the hard path. The question is not which type am I, but rather: what is the current condition of each part of my heart, and which parts are blocking the fruit that God's Word should be producing?

Mark 4:14-20 (ESV)

"The sower sows the word. And these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them. And these are the ones sown on rocky ground: the ones who, when they hear the word, immediately receive it with joy. And they have no root in themselves, but endure for a while; then, when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately they fall away. And others are the ones sown among thorns. They are those who hear the word, but the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches and the desires for other things enter in and choke the word, and it proves unfruitful. But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold."

Notice what Jesus is saying about each soil type in terms of the Volume 1 hearing chain. The hard path: the word lands but is immediately taken. The channel closes before anything takes root. The rocky soil: the word enters, faith begins to form, and then tribulation applies pressure that the shallow root system cannot support. The thorny soil: the word enters, something begins to grow, but the energy of the thorns — cares, deceitfulness of riches, desires for other things — chokes it before it can produce fruit. Only the good soil completes the full chain: word in, genuine hearing, acceptance, fruit.

The thorny soil is the most important category for Vol 2's purposes. The thorns are not sin in the simple sense — they are competing energetic loads. The word got in. Something is growing. But the thorns are consuming the available energy and attention, and the result is no fruit. This is exactly the condition I am calling an emotional knot, and it is the subject of the next exploration.

The Diagnostic Questions

The practical use of the Sower parable as a diagnostic tool is to ask, honestly, about specific areas of my life:

- Where is the Word lands but immediately gets stolen before it takes root? What is the surface condition of that part of my heart — what has hardened it?
- Where is something growing but without the depth to survive pressure? What would it take to get roots down deeper in that area, to remove the rocks?
- Where is something growing but being choked by competing energetic loads — worry, distraction, unresolved grief, accumulated resentment? What are the thorn bushes in that particular region?
- Where is the Word actually producing fruit? What conditions in that part of my life created the good soil? Can those conditions be replicated elsewhere? Can good soil replace other types of soil?

These are not rhetorical questions. They are the starting point for the diagnostic work of Part I. I am asking you to do what I have had to do: sit with the parable and let it be a mirror, not a window.

Proposed Law (Diagnostic): The four soil types in the parable of the Sower describe four conditions of the human heart, not just four categories of people. Most hearts contain all four conditions simultaneously in different regions. The diagnostic work of Vol 2 is to identify the specific soil condition in specific areas of my interior life — and to match the right clearing tool to the right soil problem.

The Three Levels of Good Soil: Not Just a Floor

One feature of the parable is particularly interesting: the good soil produces three different harvest levels. Thirty-fold. Sixty-fold. One hundred-fold. Jesus does not explain what distinguishes them, but my research on the Affective Taxonomy, which describes how values are progressively internalized through five identifiable stages, offers a formal framework for understanding this. See the Formation documents.

The four soil types map to the first four levels of the taxonomy in a way that is too precise to be coincidental. The hard path corresponds to pre-Level 1 (maybe call it Level 0): the word lands, but there is no real engagement, and the Enemy takes it immediately. The rocky soil corresponds to Level 1 (Responding): genuine engagement begins, with visible enthusiasm, but the motivation is still largely external — social, circumstantial — and the roots do not go deep enough to survive pressure. The thorny soil sits somewhere at Level 2: something is growing, but competing energetic loads (the cares of the world, the deceitfulness of riches) choke the development before it reaches the internalized-valuing threshold of Level 3+.

The three levels of good soil map to Levels 3, 4, and 5 of the taxonomy: (3) Valuing — pursuing the Word intrinsically, not because anyone is watching; (4) Organization — the Word integrated into a coherent value system that informs every domain of life; (5) Characterization — the Word so thoroughly internalized that it has become a defining characteristic of who the person is, not just what they do. The 100-fold harvest is a person at Level 5: not deliberating about whether to obey, because hearing and obeying have become who they are.

This mapping has a direct practical implication for the diagnostic work of Vol 2. The question is not just “what type of soil am I?” but “what level of good-soil internalization am I at in this specific area, and what does movement to the next level require?” The answer to that second question differs for

Levels 3, 4, and 5 from that for Levels 1 and 2. The tools in Explorations 2 through 6 primarily focus on clearing the obstacles that prevent Level 1 and Level 2 soil from becoming Level 3+. The practices in Parts II and III concern what sustains and deepens the journey from Level 3 through Level 5.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *High confidence. Jesus' own interpretation of the parable in Mark 4:14-20 supports the soil-as-heart-condition reading. The Affective Taxonomy mapping is new but internally consistent and supported by my research. The multi-region interpretation of a single heart is an inference, but one supported by Jer. 17:9 and the general witness of anyone who has tried to live the spiritual life with honest self-observation.*

VOL 1 CONNECTION: The diagnostic framework here directly aligns with the Vol 1 hearing chain (Word → Hearing → Faith, Vol 1 Exp. 1) and the nested person structure (Vol 1 Exp. 2). The hard-path soil depicts the channel being closed before the Word can take root in the spirit. The rocky soil indicates faith being generated, but the heart lacks enough depth to sustain it. The thorny soil is the most operationally significant: it shows faith being created, but competing energetic loads prevent it from reaching the stage of obedient action that would confirm and deepen it.

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The four soil types, representing four conditions of the same heart, directly align with the level structure of the Affective Taxonomy in HFT and MSFIG. Hard-path soil (word sown but not received) corresponds to Affective Level 1 or below — the person is not yet attending. Rocky soil (initial response, shallow roots) aligns with Level 1 — genuine response but extrinsically motivated, lacking the depth for sustained obedience. Thorny soil (real growth; distractions compete) relates to Level 2. The transition to Level 3 — the most critical and challenging threshold in the entire taxonomy, where competing values test emerging intrinsic motivation. Good soil (30-, 60-, 100-fold) matches Levels 3, 4, and 5, respectively. This connection is intentional: the MSFIG paper explicitly states that the Parable of the Sower is the primary scriptural test of the Affective Taxonomy, and Jesus' interpretive key in Mark 4:13 emphasizes that this parable is essential for hearing and obeying any parable. That makes this the meta-discipline of all formation and therefore essential.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 1B — DIAGNOSTIC LAW

First Exploration (B): Wound vs. Sin — The Structural Distinction

A Distinction the Volume Has Always Operated On

The Heart Soil diagnostic in Exploration 1 names *that* something is blocking growth in a given region of the heart; it does not name *what kind* of blockage it is. The corpus has been operating on a structural distinction between two categories of blockage for as long as I have been writing this volume, but I have never stated the distinction in a single place. This Exploration does.

The two categories are **wounds** and **sin**. A wound is what was *done to* the person — suffered, often pre-volitional, often inflicted before the person had agency to refuse it, calling for healing and the Spirit's truth-encounter. A sin is what the person *has done* — owned, volitional, calling for confession and where applicable restoration. The two categories require different pastoral responses, route to different tool families, and carry different theological weight. The diagnostic discernment of which category a given blockage falls into is a Companion competency — and conflating the two miscarries the response in either direction.

When a wound is misdiagnosed as a sin, the participant is sent to confession for what was done to them, which compounds shame and forecloses on the healing the wound actually needs. When a sin is misdiagnosed as a wound, the participant is offered healing for what they did, which forecloses on the confession the sin actually requires. Either error leaves the participant worse off than no intervention at all. The diagnostic question — *is this primarily wound or primarily sin?* — is therefore not a refinement detail; it is structurally upstream of the tool selection in Exploration 6.

The categories are not mutually exclusive. Most actual situations carry both: a wound that has hardened into a habit of sinning out of the wound; a sin that has been suffered as a wound by someone else; a long marriage carrying both wronging and being-wronged in the same person. But the structural distinction holds at the diagnostic altitude even when the situations are mixed; the Companion's discernment is to name which category is operating in *this* moment of the work and route the response accordingly.

A Clarifying Clause for the Reformed Tradition

I want to be explicit about one thing the Reformed tradition would (rightly) be alert to in a wound-vs-sin framing. The distinction is not a claim that wounds exist in a moral vacuum outside the broader sin-condition of the person. They do not. Every wound is suffered by a person who is themselves under the gospel's account of human sinfulness; wound work is undertaken *under* the sin-condition, not in escape from it. The structural distinction names that wound and sin operate as different mechanisms requiring different responses *within* the broader theological frame of the gospel, not that wound work somehow exempts the participant from the gospel's account of who they are.

Proposed Law (Diagnostic): Heart blockages fall into two structurally distinct categories: wounds (what was done to the person, suffered, often pre-volitional, calling for healing and the Spirit's truth-encounter) and sin (what the person has done, owned, calling for confession and where applicable restoration). The two categories require different pastoral responses and different tool families. Diagnostic discernment of which category a given blockage falls into is a Companion competency, and conflating the two miscarries the response in either

direction. The categories are not mutually exclusive — most actual situations carry both — but the diagnostic distinction is structural. Two clauses sit alongside the structural distinction. Reformed clarifying clause: wound work itself is undertaken under the broader sin-condition of the person, not in escape from it. Balancing clause: the wound is genuinely what was done to the participant, the participant is not at fault for what was done to her, and the broader sin-condition does not erase the pre-volitional character of the wound or assign her responsibility for it. Pre-volitional traumatic wounds enter under the sin-condition of those who wounded her, not under her own (cf. Ezek. 18:20; Matt. 18:6; the testimony of Tamar in 2 Sam. 13:1–22). Wound work and confession of personal sin are both required of the disciple; they are not the same work, and they do not collapse into each other.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *One of the corpus's most load-bearing implicit distinctions. The entire architecture of Vol 2 Part I has depended on this distinction; the May 2026 canonization (Council Batch 1, Claim 1, accepted May 11, 2026) makes the structural claim explicit. The categories are visible in scripture (Psalm 147:3 for the wound side; 1 John 1:9 for the sin side; Hebrews 12:15 distinguishing root-of-bitterness from sin), but the explicit structural distinction is not in any single biblical text — it is an inference from the pattern of scriptural treatment of the two poles. The Reformed-friendly clarifying clause addresses the foreseeable concern that any wound-before-sin framing escapes total depravity; the balancing clause added in v5_6_o_9 addresses the foreseeable pastoral concern (Eldredge's, in particular) that the Reformed clause could be heard by a wounded participant as handing her a portion of responsibility for what was done to her. Together the two clauses hold the doctrinal and pastoral altitudes of the wound/sin distinction without collapsing either into the other.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V2.Exp1 (Heart Soil — the broader diagnostic frame). Downstream: V2.Exp2 / V2.Exp2A (wound side targets the energetic and identity blockage laws); V2.Exp4 (sin side routes to confession); V2.Exp6 (Tool Map sorts tools by which category they address); V2.Exp6A (image-bearing dignity work assumes the wound/sin distinction).

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 2 — OPERATIONAL LAW

Second Exploration: Emotional Knots — The Energetic Blockage Law



Where This Discovery Came From

Years ago, Carolyn and I were praying for a young woman who was presenting with physical symptoms. In the middle of that prayer time, the Lord showed me a picture: a large-diameter rope, knotted in her gut. That was unusual enough. But what made it diagnostic rather than just visual was what came next: I saw that she was pulling on both ends of that rope herself. She was the one keeping it tight. The knot was not just something that had happened to her — it was something she was actively maintaining, even though it was costing her enormous energy to do so. When I offered her this picture, she confirmed it and knew she had to work on releasing her hold on the rope/knot.

That picture has stayed with me and expanded over the thirty-plus years since. I now believe emotional knots are one of the primary mechanisms by which the hearing channel described in Volume 1 gets blocked. Not the only mechanism, but the most underestimated one, because it operates below the level of conscious will. You cannot simply decide your way out of an emotional knot. If you could, you would have done it already.

What a Knot Actually Is

Let me define the term clearly as I can. An emotional knot is a sustained energetic load on the heart, created by an unresolved wound, an incomplete communication, or a lie believed. It presents as a valley in the landscape of my emotional life — a depression in the terrain that exerts gravitational pull every time I come near it. When I am inside the valley, I have reduced bandwidth: less capacity for attention, less available will, less ability to hear or respond to anything outside the demands of the valley itself.

The mechanism that makes it self-sustaining is a reinforcing feedback loop: the knot drains the bandwidth needed to hear the truth that could set it free. I cannot think my way out because my capacity to think is being consumed by the knot. I cannot will my way out because my will is being consumed. The loop is stable, and it runs in both directions. A deeper wound creates a stronger knot, more drainage, and less capacity for healing.

What breaks the loop is not my effort. It is an outside force, specifically, the ministry of the Holy Spirit, delivering truth to the part of the heart where the knot is held. That is why the tools in Part II are not self-improvement techniques; they are preparation conditions that create the access point

for the Spirit to work. The Spirit does the releasing. The tools help create the conditions for receiving the Holy Spirit's work.

Four Primary Types

Grief Knots

Grief knots arise from loss: death, divorce, betrayal, departure, the loss of a dream, a relationship, or a version of myself. Their characteristic behavioral signature is what I call the speed bump — an unexpected encounter with a reminder of the loss that pulls me back to the edge of the valley. The well-meaning friend who says exactly the wrong thing. The song that plays in the grocery store. The date on the calendar I forgot to brace for.

The energy dynamic of a grief knot is primarily one of incomplete mourning. The loss happened; the grief process got interrupted or was never safe to complete; and the unprocessed grief went underground, where it continued to consume energy. The Grief Recovery Handbook work helps identify and name the specific unfinished communications. TPM (Transformation Prayer Ministry) can create an access point for the Holy Spirit to complete the healing.

Shame Knots

Shame knots arise from experiences — usually early ones — where I received the message, verbally or circumstantially, that I am fundamentally defective. Not that I did something wrong, but that I am something wrong. The distinction matters enormously because it changes what kind of work can reach it. Guilt says, "I did a bad thing." Shame says, "I am a bad thing." Confession addresses guilt. Shame requires a revelation of identity.

I discovered the behavioral signature of shame knots by accident, while thinking about what makes things funny. The observation is this: most jokes work by shaming someone or something. The laughter is a release of tension — specifically, shame tension. And the more intensely funny I find a particular joke, the closer that joke came to a live shame place in me. My response to a given joke is, therefore, a rough diagnostic of my shame landscape: the funniest things point to the deepest shame deposits.

Shadow work — the gold-and-shadow hotseat process from the Band of Brothers material — is an effective tool I have found for shame knots, because it approaches shame obliquely rather than directly. The "shadow" is the disowned part of the self, the part I am most ashamed of and have therefore hidden. The "gold" is the God-given strength that got buried with the shame. Recovering the gold is how the shame knot gets released and makes the effort worth it.

Fear Knots

Fear knots arise from experienced or anticipated threat. They are the most physically expressed of the four types, because the fear response activates the body's threat system and produces physical symptoms — elevated heart rate, constricted breathing, hypervigilance — that are themselves draining. Fear knots also produce the most characteristic avoidance patterns: entire regions of my life that I have organized around not going near the thing that activated the fear.

The somatic entry point — breath, body awareness, progressive relaxation — is usually needed before cognitive or spiritual work can reach a fear knot. The body has to come out of the threat-response posture before the heart can open enough to receive anything. This is not therapy; it is physiology in the service of spiritual access.

Anger Knots

Anger knots arise from injustice — from being wronged and not having that wrong acknowledged, addressed, or resolved. It can also come from unmet expectations in general. The energy of the anger compresses when it has nowhere to go, and compressed anger becomes either rage (explosive release, usually disproportionate to the immediate trigger) or resentment (a slow burn that contaminates everything downstream from it). Not a stretch to consider this a root of bitterness that springs up and defiles many (Heb 12:15).

Forgiveness is the primary spiritual tool for anger knots — but forgiveness is not the same as suppression, and the distinction is critical. Suppression pushes the compressed anger deeper, where it continues to run. Genuine forgiveness releases my claim to be the one who settles the score. That is not an act of will I perform; it is a gift the Spirit gives me when I bring the anger honestly to Him and ask Him to carry it. I have to name the wrong before I can release the claim. Which is why the sequence is: honest acknowledgment of the injustice, then the choice to offer it to God, then the Spirit's release of the grip. This is the real deal, because God says, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay." He will do a better job than I can anyway.

The Common Structure Across All Four Types

Heb. 12:1 (ESV)

"Therefore, since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely, and let us run with endurance the race that is set before us."

The writer of Hebrews makes a critical distinction that I want to hold on to: weight (onkos—burden, mass) and sin are listed separately. Both slow the runner down. But they are addressed differently. Sin is confessed. Weight is laid aside. The weight may not be sin at all — it may be a legitimate grief, a valid fear, an understandable anger at a real injustice. But it still has to be laid aside because the weight carried, rather than released, slows the runner, regardless of its moral status.

Emotional knots are weights. They may have sin mixed into them often; there may be some sin component in how I have responded to the original wound. But the primary category is weight, not sin, and treating weight as primarily a sin problem creates spiritual performance pressure that makes the knot tighter, not looser.

John 8:32 (ESV)

"...and you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."

This is the mechanism statement. The truth that sets free is not information; it is revelation delivered by the Spirit of Truth to the specific part of the heart that is holding the knot. The setting free is an event, not a process of intellectual persuasion. I have seen this happen many times — in my own life and in the lives of men I have prayed with. The knot releases. The valley levels out. The bandwidth returns. Not gradually, but suddenly, when the Spirit speaks the specific truth into the specific place.

Prov. 4:23 (ESV)

"Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life."

The active maintenance of a well-kept heart is the positive version of this law. When the knots are cleared, and I am actively keeping the heart clear, the wellsprings of life flow. This is not a metaphor for nice feelings; it is a description of what the Word and the Spirit can do in and through me when the channel is unobstructed.

Dmitri Bilgere adds one more layer here that I think is worth naming, because it explains something I had observed for years but never quite articulated: why men hold onto knots even when they sincerely want to be free of them.

He identifies two reasons. The first is that the knot feels like a control mechanism. The shaming voice that says you will fail, the anxiety that keeps you vigilant, the anger that holds a boundary — on some level, you believe this thing is protecting you. It is painful protection, but protection nonetheless. What Dmitri found is that when you ask that voice what it actually wants for you, the answer is almost always something legitimate: safety, belonging, respect, love. The method is wrong, but the desire is not bad. And when the protective voice can see that its strategy isn't working — that it is often making things worse — it becomes willing to let go. Not because it has been defeated, but because it has been heard.

The second reason is harder to name. You may be holding the knot as a way of staying connected to someone you love. If a parent, a sibling, or someone important to you lived with this kind of pain — grief, shame, the expectation of rejection — you may have taken it on yourself as a form of loyalty or solidarity. You are suffering their suffering. The connection feels real because it is real. The problem is that it doesn't help them, and it is draining you.

Both dynamics show up in knot work. When a man has engaged a tool correctly, and the knot doesn't release, the question to ask is: Does letting go feel dangerous, or does it feel like a betrayal? The answer tells you which dynamic is operating, and therefore what the Spirit needs to speak into that specific place.

Proposed Law (Operational): An emotional knot is a sustained energetic load on the heart created by unresolved loss, a believed lie, experienced injustice, unconfessed sin, or incomplete communication. It operates as a self-sustaining feedback loop that drains the bandwidth of attention and will that is required for genuine hearing. The release mechanism in every case is a revelation of truth delivered by the Holy Spirit to the specific part of the heart holding the knot. No tool releases a knot apart from the ministry of the Spirit; the tools help create the conditions for the Spirit to work.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *Mechanism is experientially confirmed over multiple decades and across many people. The four-type taxonomy is a working hypothesis — the categories may overlap, and the boundaries may be less clean than stated. Community testing will sharpen this. The distinction between weight and sin (Heb. 12:1) is high-confidence; the specific release mechanism is high-confidence; the tool-to-type mapping in Exploration 6 is medium-confidence.*

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The emotional knot functions as a self-sustaining feedback loop that depletes the bandwidth of attention and will, which are essential for genuine listening. SST's soul Level 1 (Awareness of Soul-Disorder) is a prerequisite for any knot-clearing work—a person who has not yet recognized that the soul is disordered (Level 1.1–1.3) will resist the diagnostic process even when others can see the knot. SST suggests that recognizing soul-disorder makes scripture's claims feel personally urgent rather than just abstract interests. This aligns precisely with the shift from Affective Level 2 (extrinsic compliance) to Level 3 (intrinsic valuing) in the heart taxonomy. The practical takeaway: the diagnostic process in this Exploration and the soul Level 1 work in SST are the same effort viewed from different perspectives. When both are done together—naming internal fragmentation and pinpointing the specific knot—the subsequent clearing work in later Explorations is more likely to succeed.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 2A — DIAGNOSTIC LAW

Second Exploration (A): The Wound and the False Self — The Identity Blockage Law



The Layer Beneath the Knots

After working with men for many years in the Band of Brothers context, and after living through my own interior clearing work, I have come to believe there is a category of blockage that sits beneath the emotional knots of Exploration 2. It is not just that I carry grief, shame, fear, or anger. It is that, over time, those knots shape a whole alternative version of me — a constructed identity that I begin to manage my life out of, rather than the real self the Father designed and is restoring. John Eldredge, in *Wild at Heart* (2001), gave me the clearest language I have found for this dynamic, and I want to give it its own formal law here.

Every man (woman) receives a wound — usually early, usually from someone he needed to be safe. The wound arrives with an interpretation, and that interpretation becomes the organizing story of his life if it goes unaddressed. Eldredge argues, and I agree, that the wound almost always strikes at the same question that sits at the center of every man's heart: Do I have what it takes? The answer the wound delivers — delivered not by reason but by experience — is “No”. And the heart, in its understandable attempt to survive that verdict, constructs a false self to manage around it. There is an equivalent dynamic for women that John and his wife, Stasi, discuss in their book “Captivating”.

Proverbs 4:23 (ESV)

“Keep your heart with all vigilance, for from it flow the springs of life.”

The heart that has organized around a wound is not keeping itself with vigilance — it is keeping itself defended. The defenses work. They prevent certain specific kinds of pain. But they also prevent the springs of life from flowing, because the same walls that keep the wound from being touched keep the Spirit from reaching it.

What the False Self Actually Is

The false self is not a mask, at least not in the simple sense. It is a coherent alternative identity, built from whatever my wound left me with. If the wound told me I am not competent, my false self may be the performer — the man who never lets anyone see him uncertain, who over-prepares for everything, who cannot rest because rest feels like exposure. If the wound told me I am fundamentally unlovable, my false self may be the helper — the man who earns a relationship through usefulness and who has no idea how to receive care without giving something back. If the

wound told me I am dangerous — that my strength hurts someone — my false self may be the nice guy, the man who has turned his intensity so far down that he barely shows up at all.

The false self is not evil. It is a survival structure built by a part of me that was trying to protect something precious. But it is not me, and living from it is expensive — it takes enormous energy to maintain, and it keeps the real man hidden, from others and from himself. I remember a man in one of my workshops talking about his mask felt like a 100-pound weight that he was carrying on the end of a 5-foot pole so people would not see who he really was. It was exhausting just listening to him. He declined to address this and eventually fell away from the faith and left his family.

This connects directly to Exploration 2's knot framework: the false self is what forms when knots go unaddressed long enough to become identity. The grief knot becomes the man who has decided that connection isn't worth the risk. The shame knot becomes the man who has decided he is permanently defective. The fear knot becomes the man who has organized his entire life around avoiding situations where the fear can activate. In each case, the knot has progressed from a wound to a worldview.

Eph. 4:22–24 (ESV)

“...to put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful desires, and to be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and to put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness.”

Paul's language here is remarkably precise. The old self is not just behavioral; it is identity-level. And the renewal is not incremental improvement; it is a putting off and a putting on, an identity transaction that the Spirit executes, not the will.

The Question and the Father's Answer

Eldredge's most useful observation, in my experience with men, is the specificity of the wound's attack. It does not merely hurt — it aims at a question. Do I have what it takes? is the version most men carry, though the precise form varies. For some it is Am I lovable? For some it is Do I matter? For some it is Is there a place for me? But the structure is the same in every case: the wound lodged a particular verdict at a particular question, and the man has been living inside that verdict ever since — either trying to disprove it (performance) or having given up on the question entirely (resignation).

The only voice that can actually answer the question is the Father's. Not a father's — though a good earthly father points toward it — but the Father's. This is the theological foundation beneath the God-Connect in Exploration 5: genuine connection with God is not primarily doctrinal. It is receiving a specific answer to a specific question that has been running through me, often below my awareness, for most of my life.

I have watched this happen in men. The moment when the Spirit speaks to that question — not in general terms but specifically, to that man, about that wound — is unmistakable. The false self, which had been load-bearing for decades, suddenly has nothing to hold up. Not because it was defeated, but because the question it was built to manage has been answered by the only voice that could settle it.

Isa. 43:1 (ESV)

“But now thus says the Lord, he who created you, O Jacob, he who formed you, O Israel: ‘Fear not, for I have redeemed you; I have called you by name, you are mine.’”

The Father calls by name. Not by category, not by performance record, not by potential. By name. That is the answer to the question the wound installed.

The Connection to Waking the Dead

In *Waking the Dead* (2003), Eldredge makes a complementary argument: the heart is good, restored in Christ. This is one of the most fought-over truths in the Christian life. The enemy does not primarily attack behavior; he attacks identity, because identity is upstream of everything. If he can keep a man living from the false self, convinced that his real heart is too dangerous or too broken to be trusted, he has effectively neutralized that man's spiritual contribution without ever having to fight him directly.

This connects to my Vol 1 framework at the structural level. If the nested person (Vol 1, Exp. 2) is designed for the Spirit to dwell in and govern from, and the enemy can keep my identity organized around the wound rather than around the Spirit's indwelling, then the Vol 1 operational laws will continue to underperform — not because they are false, but because the identity structure through which they must operate is pointed in the wrong direction. The pipe is not just clogged; it is connected to the wrong supply.

Proposed Law (Diagnostic): Every unaddressed wound installs a verdict about the self, and a self organized around that verdict develops a false self as a management structure. The false self is not sin in the simple sense — it is a survival identity that gradually replaces the Spirit-led self as the operating center of a person's life. The release mechanism is not behavioral reform; it is the Father speaking a specific true answer to the specific question that the wound lodged. Until that answer is received, the false self remains load-bearing, and the Vol 1 operational laws are partially obstructed at the level of identity.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred. The wound-false self structure is observationally consistent across decades of work with men and in my own interior experience. Eldredge's framing in *Wild at Heart* is the clearest articulation I have encountered, though the underlying dynamics are present in Payne and Bennett as well. The specificity of the question is a working hypothesis — the precise form varies by person and wound. The Father's answering mechanism is high-confidence; I have seen it operate too many times to doubt it.

VOL 1 CONNECTION: The identity blockage law operates at the structural level of Vol 1, Exp. 2 (Spirit, Heart, Soul, Body). A false self organized around a wound redirects the Heart — the volitional center — away from the Spirit and toward the wound-management system. The operational laws of Vol 1 continue to function, but they are partially filtered through a set of identity commitments that distort their output. Clearing the identity blockage is not separate from the Vol 1 work — it is what makes the Vol 1 laws fully accessible.

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The false self as described here corresponds directly to SST's soul Stage 1 (Awareness of Soul-Disorder) and Stage 2 (Submission and Surrender). A person whose identity is organized around the wound is in an arrested pre-Stage 3 condition — even if behavioral compliance places them at what looks like a higher stage. A man running from the false self may perform at Level 4; his actual soul integration is stuck at Stage 2 until the identity transaction described in this law takes place.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 2B — DIAGNOSTIC LAW

Second Exploration (B): The Adversary's Role — Why the Knots Don't Just Happen

A Dimension I Have Understated

When I describe emotional knots, I describe them primarily in terms of their mechanisms, how they form, how they sustain themselves, and how they block hearing. What I have not said clearly enough is this: they do not just happen. There is a personal intelligence behind the installation of the most damaging ones, and treating the knot-clearing work as purely psychological, without naming that intelligence, leaves a dimension of the problem unaddressed.

John Eldredge addresses this directly and carefully in *Waking the Dead* (2003), and I think he is right. The enemy's primary strategy is not the dramatic temptation to gross sin. It is the quiet, patient installation of a lie in a moment of vulnerability, followed by a long campaign to keep that lie in place — to make sure the healing that would dislodge it never quite happens, that the community that would provide the safe container for healing never quite forms, and that the man himself never quite believes his own heart is worth the fight.

1 Pet. 5:8 (ESV)

"Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary, the devil, prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour."

This is not a dramatic metaphor. It is a description of an active, intentional, personal adversary. The prowling is patient. The seeking is specific. A lion does not devour herds; it selects the vulnerable individual and separates him from the group before striking. That is a precise description of how spiritual attack operates, in my observation: it targets the isolatable, the already wounded, the one who has drifted from community.

The Specific Strategy Eldredge Names

Eldredge proposes in *Waking the Dead* that the enemy's primary target is the heart, and his primary tactic is to get the man to mishandle it — either to shut the heart down (live from the false self, keep everything managed and defended) or to hand the heart to the wrong things (fill the design desires with substitutes that consume but do not satisfy). Both strategies accomplish the same thing: a man whose heart is not alive and not directed where it was designed to go is effectively neutralized, without the enemy ever having to fight him directly.

This maps precisely onto the knot framework from Exploration 2. Grief knots are often perpetuated by the lie that the mourning is not safe to complete — that the pain is too big, or that finishing the grief means losing the person again. This lie has a source. Shame knots are perpetuated by the lie that the shameful thing is definitionally true — that what happened reveals what I fundamentally am. This lie has a source. Fear knots are perpetuated by the lie that the feared outcome is both inevitable and unsurvivable. This lie has a source. Anger knots are perpetuated by the lie that forgiveness means letting the injustice stand unchallenged. This lie has a source. The source is not just the wound. The wound provided the entry point. The enemy provided the interpretation.

John 10:10 (ESV)

“The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy. I came that they may have life and have it abundantly.”

This is a structural statement about two opposing intentions and two opposing strategies. The abundant life Jesus describes is not general flourishing; it is the specific fullness that flows from a heart fully alive and fully connected — through the four connects of Exploration 5, as one way, to the source of that life. The thief's strategy is the systematic removal of that fullness: stealing hearing, killing hope, destroying community. The knot framework describes the mechanisms; this verse names the agent.

What This Means for the Clearing Work

I want to be careful here, because the spiritual warfare framing can be used badly — to explain away responsibility, to make every struggle feel like an attack rather than a consequence, or to generate a theatrical vigilance that is itself a distraction from the real interior work. Eldredge is careful about this in *Waking the Dead*, and I want to be equally careful.

Naming the adversary does not reduce my responsibility for the clearing work. The knots are mine to address. The tools are mine to use. The community is mine to seek and maintain. Naming the adversary changes my posture going into the work: I am not just dealing with my own psychology. I am recovering something that is being actively contested. And the recovery happens in the context of a larger story — a battle with real stakes.

The practical implication is one I have observed repeatedly: knot-clearing work that includes explicit spiritual warfare prayer — not dramatic or theatrical, but honest and direct — tends to produce more durable results than the same process done without it. When I name, out loud and before God, that I am not just addressing a psychological pattern but reclaiming contested ground, something shifts. The Spirit seems to honor the fuller picture of what is actually happening.

Eph. 6:12 (ESV)

“For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places.”

Paul's language is precise: the wrestling is real, and the opponent is not human. This is not an invitation to paranoia; it is an invitation to accurate diagnosis. When a man is stuck — when the tool is correct, and the conditions are right, and the knot is not releasing — the question worth asking is: is there a spiritual dimension to this resistance that has not yet been addressed? In my experience, the answer is sometimes yes, and when it is, the spiritual warfare prayer opens the door that the psychological process alone could not.

Proposed Law (Diagnostic): Emotional and cognitive knots do not form in a neutral environment. The enemy of the soul targets moments of vulnerability to instill specific lies and then works through isolation, discouragement, and misdirection to keep those lies in place. The clearing work of Part II is therefore not purely psychological — it is a recovery of ground that is being actively contested. Spiritual warfare prayer, honest and specific, is a legitimate and often necessary component of the clearing process. Naming the adversary accurately neither reduces my responsibility for the work nor inflates the adversary's power — it clarifies the actual nature of the contest so that the right resources can be brought to it.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred. The scriptural case is clear, and I hold it with high confidence. The practical observation — that clearing work done with explicit spiritual warfare prayer is more durable — is consistent across my experience but has not been formally tested. The caution about the theatrical misuse of spiritual warfare framing is real, and I would rather err on the side of understatement here than give an excuse to blame an external agent for everything that is actually their own work.

VOL 1 CONNECTION: The adversary's strategy — targeting the hearing channel — maps directly onto the Vol 1 Word → Hearing → Faith operational law (Vol 1, Exp. 1). Mark 4:15 makes this explicit: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them. The adversary is not passive in the Sower parable. He is active at the point of reception. The adversary's lies also operate on V1.FL.III (Heart-Throne): the lie installed at the moment of vulnerability is rarely a free-standing falsehood. It is a promise — this will give you what you need, this will keep you safe, this will make you valuable. That is the structure of idolatry, and naming the lie's implicit proposed throne-occupant is part of how the lie is undone.

Vol 2 — Exploration 2C — Diagnostic Law

Second Exploration (C): Standing Interior Agreements

A Third Sibling to Wound-and-False-Self and the Adversary's Role

Explorations 2A and 2B named two layers beneath the knots of Exploration 2: the *wound-and-false-self* pattern, where the knot has hardened into an identity (2A); and the *adversary's role* in installing lies at moments of vulnerability (2B). This Exploration names a third sibling layer that the corpus has been operating on for decades, especially in the BoB and Fellowship of the Heart contexts, but that I have never given a formal home in this volume until now: **standing interior agreements** — binding contracts the participant entered (often as a child, often during specific trauma moments, often unconsciously) about who they are, what they are worth, what they are permitted to do or to be, and how they are loyal to the family system.

The agreement is *operationally distinct* from a knot. A knot is what the participant is *carrying* — a sustained energetic load on the heart, in the language of Exploration 2. An agreement is what the participant has *committed to carrying* — a binding interior contract that produces and re-produces knots across multiple blockage-types over years and decades. A single agreement may produce grief knots (committed to mourning incompletely because completion would feel like disloyalty), shame knots (committed to a verdict about the self as the price of belonging), fear knots (committed to a survival strategy out of which the fear cannot be released), anger knots (committed to a contract that forbids the anger from being named), and sin-channel behaviors (committed to a pattern that the agreement requires) — *all from the same underlying agreement*.

This has a sharp practical implication. **Addressing the downstream knots without naming the upstream agreement clears each knot individually without dissolving the binding that produces them.** The participant can do beautiful knot-clearing work on grief and shame and fear and anger and feel real release in each — and find six months later that the same patterns have re-formed because the standing agreement is still in force, still producing the same knots from upstream. The agreement-territory is upstream of the knot-territory; both must be addressed for full healing.

The Operational Form: Renunciation Work

The corpus's canonical protocol for renouncing standing interior agreements is **A25 Breaking the Contracts**, which operates in Exploration 9's territory (Community as Amplifier) with **corporate prayer in Jesus's name as the operational form of the renunciation**. The protocol is treated at depth in Vol 5 Part VI. What matters at the canonical-claim altitude is that renunciation is the right form for this territory — naming the agreement, formally renouncing it in the name of Jesus, with the community as witness and amplifier — because an agreement, by its nature, is exited by a counter-act that has the same authority-structure as the original entering act. A contract entered in a child's vulnerable moment is exited by an adult renunciation in the authority of the Lord, in community, before witnesses. The form matches the territory.

Two boundary notes. **First**, the renunciation is of the *contract-message*, not of the parent or person who was its human conduit; the parent retains image-bearing dignity throughout (Exploration 6A). The work is the gospel's freedom to address the contract directly without dishonoring the conduit. **Second**, agreement-renunciation work is Companion II / III competency; it is not first-cohort beginner work. Vol 5 Part VI's A25 entry treats the gating in detail.

Proposed Law (Diagnostic): In addition to the wound-and-false-self pattern (V2.Exp2A) and the adversary's role in installing lies (V2.Exp2B), participants carry standing interior agreements — binding contracts the participant entered (often as a child, often during specific trauma moments, often unconsciously) about who they are, what they are worth, what they are permitted to do or to be, and how they are loyal to the family system. The agreement is operationally distinct from a knot: a knot is what the participant is carrying; an agreement is what the participant has committed to carrying. Standing interior agreements produce knots across multiple blockage-types — a single agreement may produce grief, shame, fear, anger, and sin-channel behaviors that all flow from the agreement's binding. Addressing the downstream knots without naming the upstream agreement clears each knot individually without dissolving the binding agreement that produces them. The agreement-territory is upstream of the knot-territory; both must be addressed for full healing. The corpus's canonical protocol for renunciation of standing interior agreements is A25 Breaking the Contracts, operating in V2.Exp9 (Community as Amplifier) with corporate prayer in Jesus's name as the operational form of the renunciation.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The claim names operational territory the A25 Phase 2 work substantively demonstrated. The Reasonably Inferred confidence reflects the territory being well-developed through A25 Phase 2 work and broader BoB / FotH pastoral practice across multiple decades, with the practitioner-experience layer continuing to mature. Synthesis-pass canonization (May 13, 2026); names what the corpus has been practicing through A25 deployment in BoB / FotH bodies for multiple decades.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V2.Exp1; V2.Exp2 (the broader diagnostic claim under which 2C sits as sibling); V2.Exp2B (agreements often arise through the adversary's targeting). Downstream: V2.Exp6 (contract/agreement *governing-axis* at Tool Map altitude); V2.Exp9 (A25's canonical home for the protocol); A25 (canonical operational protocol — Vol 5 Part VI).

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 3 — OPERATIONAL LAW

Third Exploration: Believing a Lie — The Cognitive Blockage Law



The Root Beneath the Root

Every emotional knot has a cognitive root — a belief about God, about myself, or about others that is false but that I have accepted as true, usually as a result of a wound or a repeated experience in which the lie was confirmed. TPM — Transformation Prayer Ministry — is built on this specific insight, and in my observation, it is correct: the Holy Spirit does not merely soothe the pain of a wound. He replaces the lie at the root of the wound with His truth. The soothing is the consequence of the replacement, not the mechanism.

This distinction is important because it explains why some inner healing work lasts and some doesn't. If the prayer gets to the lie and the Spirit speaks truth into that specific place, the knot releases and stays released. If the prayer produces emotional relief without reaching the lie, the relief is real but temporary — the lie is still running underneath, and the knot will re-form.

Where the Lies Come From

The most persistent lies are not ones I consciously adopted. They were installed by events — usually events in which I was young and had no interpretive framework, so I accepted the worst possible interpretation of what happened. A father's absence becomes "I am not worth staying for." A mother's rage becomes "I am the cause of bad things." An early failure becomes "I am fundamentally inadequate." A betrayal becomes "I cannot trust anyone." These are not conclusions I reasoned my way to; they are conclusions I absorbed because they were the only frame available in the moment.

John 8:44 (ESV)

"...He was a murderer from the beginning, and does not stand in the truth, because there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks out of his own character, for he is a liar and the father of lies."

The adversary's primary weapon is not temptation to gross sin; it is the installation of a small, plausible-sounding lie in a moment of vulnerability. The lie is most effective when it is delivered in a moment of genuine pain, because pain reduces my interpretive capacity and makes me more likely to accept the first available explanation for what is happening. That first available explanation is almost always worse than the truth.

Eph. 4:22-24 (ESV)

"...to put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life and is corrupt through deceitful desires, and to be renewed in the spirit of your minds, and to put on the new self, created after the likeness of God in true righteousness and holiness."

Paul's language here is relevant: the old self is "corrupt through deceitful desires" — the corruption runs through a system of desire that has been shaped by deception. The renewal of the mind is not just new information; it is the dismantling of the deceptive framework and the reinstallation of a framework shaped by truth. That is a Spirit operation, not a study exercise.

Dave Smith and our Band of Brothers spent years watching the lie-formation mechanism work in men's lives, and what we observed is that the pathway from wound to belief is almost never direct. There is usually a middle step that determines how the lie crystallizes and how stubborn it becomes.

The middle step is the vow.

When a wound arrives — especially early, especially from someone who should have been safe — the heart does something understandable: it makes a decision. "I will never let anyone humiliate me like that again." "I cannot do anything right." "The only person I can trust is myself." These are not conscious philosophical positions. They are survival decisions made in the moment of injury by a part of a person who was trying to prevent the same thing from happening twice. The vow is the wound hardened into policy.

What makes vows particularly difficult to work with is that they feel like wisdom rather than a wound. They have served the person — or at least appeared to — for so long that they are now part of how the person understands reality. The man who decided in childhood that he cannot trust anyone may have built his entire adult relational architecture on that foundation. The belief is not just something he holds; it is a load-bearing wall. Which is why dismantling it requires the Spirit, not just information. You cannot argue someone out of a structural component of their identity, even if the component is false.

Smith adds the observation that vows made from wounds eventually become internal idols — structures the person worships with their attention and energy, feeds with their choices, and sacrifices other things to maintain. This is where Dmitri Bilgere's Idol Breaking process (described later in this exploration) fits most precisely: it targets the false god implied by the vow-become-belief. Seeing that a small-g god named and externalized is often the key that allows a person to finally reject it and seek the real one.

The TPM Process as a Law Application



Transformation Prayer Ministry gives the Holy Spirit access to specific memories where particular lies were accepted and invites Him to speak His truth into those places. The process is essentially a

focused application of John 8:32: creating the conditions for the Spirit of Truth to replace a specific lie with specific truth.

The sequence: I identify a present emotional disturbance — something that is activating a knot right now. I follow that emotion backward to its earliest associated memory. In that memory, I identify the belief I formed — the lie I accepted about what the event meant about God, myself, or others. I invite the Holy Spirit to speak. He speaks. The lie is replaced. The emotion in the present shifts, often dramatically and immediately.

I have seen this work too many times to doubt the mechanism. What I am less certain about is why it works in some sessions and not others — and I believe the answer is primarily in the conditions of the heart coming into the session. A heart that is genuinely submitted, genuinely willing to hear whatever the Spirit says (including uncomfortable things), and genuinely in community with other believers who are praying, seems to produce consistently better access. This connects this directly to the obedience channel law from Volume 1: my willingness to obey what I hear is the channel condition that determines what I can receive.

Proposed Law (Operational): Every emotional knot has a cognitive root—a specific lie accepted about God, self, or others during a moment of vulnerability. The lie sustains the knot beneath conscious awareness. Release requires the Holy Spirit to speak specific truth into the exact memory where the lie was accepted. This is not about transferring information; it is Spirit-to-spirit revelation that bypasses the cognitive defenses the lie has built around itself.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The lie-at-the-root mechanism is consistent with TPM theory and with my direct observation. The specific mechanism by which the Spirit accesses and replaces the lie is not fully understood — this is the frontier of the spiritual calculus and will be discussed in Vol 3.*

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The lie-at-the-root mechanism described here is the core aspect of SST's soul Stage 3.3 (Memory and Narrative Reordering). It involves reinterpreting past wounds and failures through sovereign grace—requiring the Holy Spirit to speak specific truth into the exact memory where the lie was accepted. SST explains the success of inner healing as the soul's integrating function being rewritten: the person's narrative of their own history is reorganized under sovereign grace rather than under the lie. The connection works both ways: this mechanism demonstrates how the Stage 3.3 outcome is produced (Spirit-to-spirit revelation that bypasses cognitive defenses); SST's Stage 3.3 description shows what the person's inner state looks like after the knot is released and the lie is replaced. Neither description is complete without the other.

Here is another door, introduced to me through Dmitri's work, and which I have found particularly useful with men who process analytically. Dmitri calls it Idol Breaking, and when I first heard the name, I nearly dismissed it as too dramatic. Don't. The name is theologically precise.



The process works by tracing a cognitive lie not just to its origin story but to the false god it implies. Here is the logic: if I have lived for twenty years with the deep, quiet belief that genuine intimacy is unavailable to me — that every time I reach for it I will be rebuffed — then I am not just holding a lie about relationships. I am implicitly believing in a god who set the world up that way. A small-g god who would create me with a bone-deep longing for connection and then fate me to a life of surface-level contact. That is an idol, and it is governing my life from below the level where I can usually see it.

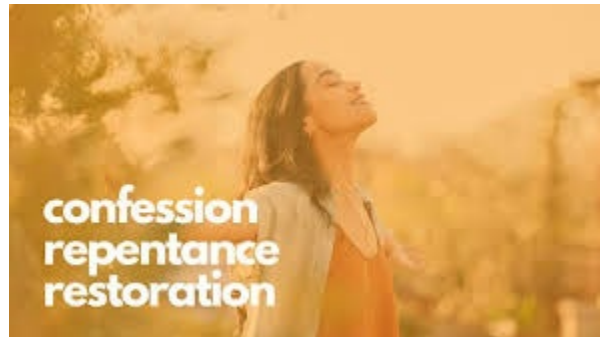
The Idol Breaking questions walk in five steps. First: What do you really want, at the deepest level — something you've gone for and given up on? Second: When you go for that, what do you hit instead? Third: When this pattern repeats, what heartbreaking fate have you started to accept? Fourth: What kind of god would set up a world where you are fated to that outcome? And fifth: Is that really the most merciful, most loving God your heart can conceive of?

Most people, when they see the small-g god their unconscious has been relating to, are surprised and then relieved. Of course, that's not the real God. They already know it's not. But they needed to see it externalized and named before they could reject it and seek the real one. And that seeking — that reorientation toward a God who is actually for them — is where the Spirit meets them and the belief begins to shift.

In IJH terms, Idol Breaking is a Tool-Application law for cognitive blockages that comes at the lie from the theological end rather than the memory end. TPM tends to be more effective when the lie is tightly anchored to a specific traumatic memory. Idol Breaking tends to be more effective when the lie is more diffuse — a general life orientation rather than a specific wound. For some men, and for some categories of lie, it is the fastest and most durable entry point. I'd recommend having both tools, knowing the difference, and letting the Spirit guide which one the blockage needs.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 4 — OPERATIONAL LAW

Fourth Exploration: Confession and Restoration — Clearing the Sin Blockage



Pairing with Vol 1 Foundational Law II

I flagged this as an Open Trail in earlier drafts of Volume 1; in v5_6_o_11 I closed the trail by formally adding the Confession-Restoration Law as Foundational Law II (V1.FL.II — throughout this volume, V1.FL.N refers to the Nth of the twelve Foundational Laws Vol 1 v5_6_o_12 carries ahead of its Explorations). In v5_6_o_12 the corpus added the Heart-Throne Law as V1.FL.III, which now sits as the structural pair to V1.FL.II: confession (the territory of this Exploration) clears the sin act, while V1.FL.III dethrones the false god the sin was serving — the answer to the question of why some sins, faithfully confessed repeatedly, return. What V1.FL.II names at law-level — the channel-clearing mechanism vertically, between person and God — this Exploration extends into the diagnostic and tool-application register; it also pairs with the Sin Blockage Law named below as the same mechanism from the opposite side. It belongs here in Vol 2 as its own full exploration, because confession is the primary tool for the sin component of heart blockage — and sin blockage is the one type that does not respond to the other tools. TPM does not clear unconfessed sin. Grief Recovery does not clear unconfessed sin. Shadow work does not clear unconfessed sin. Only confession does.

At the same time, the Hebrews 12:1 distinction I drew in Exploration 2 applies here: confession is the right tool for sin, but not for weight that is not sin. Using confession as a one-size-fits-all tool for heart blockage is a common mistake in my observation, and it produces spiritual performance pressure that damages rather than heals. The first diagnostic task is always: is this primarily a sin problem or primarily a weight problem? The answer determines the tool.

The Law and Its Negative

1 John 1:9 (ESV)

"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."

This is a clean operational if-then. The condition is confession. The result is forgiveness and cleansing. The cleansing language is important — it is not merely legal acquittal; it is a restoration of the clean condition of the channel. Unconfessed sin leaves a residue that suppresses the flow of the Spirit through me. Confession removes the residue.

Ps. 66:18 (ESV)

"If I had cherished iniquity in my heart, the Lord would not have listened."

This is the negative version of the law, and it is stark. Cherished iniquity — sin that I am holding onto rather than releasing — is not neutral in its effect. It is not just that the Lord is disappointed in me. It is that the hearing channel closes. He does not listen. This is not punitive arbitrariness; it is a systems consequence. I cannot be genuinely submitted to God and genuinely unwilling to release a specific sin simultaneously. The contradiction resolves in one direction or the other.

What Genuine Confession Looks Like

Genuine confession is not the recitation of a category “I have sinned against you in thought, word, and deed.” That form has its place in liturgy, but it does not do the specific work that 1 John 1:9 describes. Genuine confession names the specific thing, owns it as mine (not as a response to circumstances or as someone else’s fault), and releases it, which means releasing also the self-justification, the rationalization, and the claim that my circumstances made it understandable.

Jas. 5:16 ESV adds the community dimension: “Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed.” The healing comes through communal confession and prayer, not because the other person has the power to forgive, but because bringing sin into the light of community breaks the secrecy that gives it power. Shame lives in secrecy. When sin is confessed in a safe, trusted community, the shame component of the sin knot is simultaneously addressed.

James 5:16 (ESV)

“Therefore, confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous person has great power as it is working.”

The last sentence connects confession directly to the Prayer as Resonance law from Volume 1. When the sin blockage is cleared through confession, the prayer of a righteous person — now actually righteous in this area, because the sin has been released — has great power as it works. Confession is therefore not merely a moral maintenance activity; it is a channel-clearing prerequisite for effective prayer.

Proposed Law (Operational): Unconfessed sin functions as a load on the spiritual circuit that prevents not only prayer but the broader therapeutic work of formation from being effective. Wound work, identity work, hearing development, and tool-application work all assume that the sin channel is being kept clear by active confession — to God, to self, where appropriate to another. Genuine confession — specific, owned, without self-justification, and releasing the sin rather than merely acknowledging it — clears this load and restores the channel. This is not a sequential prerequisite (the formation work does not pause for perfect sin-clearing) but an ongoing precondition that the Companion attends to alongside the other work. The Companion's discipline is to keep the confession channel available, not to make it the gateway through which all formation must pass. The diagnostic question is always: is this blockage primarily sin (requiring confession) or primarily weight (requiring a different tool)?

Certainty: Clearly Taught — Among the highest-confidence laws in the entire IJH project. Scriptural grounding is explicit and bidirectional — positive and negative cases both stated. The broadened scope (from prayer-and-hearing to all therapeutic formation work) is supported by the same scriptural and experiential ground; the mechanism is unchanged. The broadening was Council-canonized May 11, 2026 (Theological Assumptions Registry, Batch 1) to make the therapeutic-precondition status across all formation work explicit; the broadening makes explicit what the downstream-dependents in this Exploration had always implied. The practical diagnostic question (sin vs. weight) is the more nuanced piece and is medium-confidence in application to specific situations.

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The central question in this law — is this blockage primarily sin (requiring confession) or primarily weight (requiring a different tool)? —

exemplifies the broader discernment challenge MSFIG addresses in its section on the Willard-Friesen debate and throughout. MSFIG's main argument is that practicing the right steps at the wrong level leads to the wrong outcome: a Level 2 compliance pattern (attending confession regularly, performing the ritual correctly) is not the same as the Level 3–4 confession this law envisions — specific, owned, free of self-justification, and genuinely releasing the sin rather than just acknowledging it. The Pharisee counterexample in MSFIG clearly illustrates this: perfect Level 2 compliance (attendance, tithing, scripture knowledge, public righteousness) mistaken for Level 5 transformation. Genuine confession, as described in this law, is an affective Level 3–4 event, not merely a behavioral Level 2 action.

PART II

Clearing: Heart Tools and How They Work

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 5 — STRUCTURAL LAW

Fifth Exploration: The Four Connects — A Causal Sequence



Not a Workshop Label — A Logical Architecture

The Four Connects — Connecting with Self, Connecting with Others, Connecting with God, Connecting with Mission — came out of the Band of Brothers work I have been doing with men for many years. We used it as an organizing framework for workshops and small group sessions. What I want to do here is elevate it from an organizational label to what I now understand it actually is: a causal sequence with directional dependencies that matter. The four connects come from the two most important commandments as Jesus highlighted (Matt. 22:37-39).

The sequence is not arbitrary. I cannot genuinely connect with Others if I do not know myself — if I have not done the interior work of Exploration 1 and 2 and understand what is going on inside me. I cannot genuinely connect with God through mere religious activity if I am not honest with myself and am carrying uncleared blockages. And I cannot find and live my Mission unless I am genuinely connected with all three of the above. The dependencies run in one direction: Self precedes Others; Others and Self together create the conditions for genuine Connection with God; and all three together make Mission sustainable rather than performative.

Connecting with Self



The starting point is always honest self-observation. "How converted is my heart?" is the diagnostic question I keep returning to, because it refuses the religious short-circuit of treating profession as equivalent to transformation. The heart is the soil. The state of the soil determines what the Word can produce. And I have a hard time addressing a soil condition I have not accurately named.

The tools for connecting with Self include: telling my story (chronologically first, then spiritually, then in terms of wounds and battles and victories), the Garden of Your Heart exercise which I will describe fully in Exploration 7, the Loss Graph from Grief Recover Handbook (GRH), the "Who Are You?" process, and the Footprints of God exercise that maps where I can see God's hand in my life history looking backward.

Let me expand on the story-telling piece, because I have come to believe it is more important than its position on that list suggests.

Dave Smith and our Band of Brothers developed a practice of telling our stories to each other — not just once, but repeatedly. The full version would take thirty minutes or more. The ten-minute version, told as though to someone who has never heard it before, is the more instructive exercise, because you discover what you lead with when you only have time for what matters most. Dave identified four questions that give the story its shape: Where are the footprints of God in this life? Where are the wounds? Where are the battles? Where have there been victories and losses? These four questions pull a chronology out of the realm of autobiography and into the realm of spiritual narrative. The same events look different under each question.

What surprised us — and this is still true for me every time I do it — is that the story comes out differently each retelling. Not wrong the last time; differently. What you lead with shifts with where you are spiritually and what you are currently being asked to see. The story seems to know what you need to hear before you do. One of our brothers said it well: something new always shows up.

The implication for Connecting with Self is that storytelling is not the opening activity before the real work begins. It is the beginning of the self-connection work, and it is never finished. A man who has told his story a dozen times in a group he trusts knows himself in a qualitatively different way from a man who has told it only once to a questionnaire. The story told in community is tested, heard, reflected back, and clarified. The story told alone stays inside the assumptions you already have. This is one reason I pushed back earlier in this volume against the individualistic reading of spiritual formation — the self you are connecting with is partly constructed through being witnessed by others. You cannot see all of yourself from inside yourself.

Ps. 139:23-24 (ESV)

"Search me, O God, and know my heart! Try me and know my thoughts! And see if there be any grievous way in me, and lead me in the way everlasting."

This is the invitation to God to do the diagnostic work of Connecting with Self on my behalf — because my self-perception is limited and distorted. The prayer is for God's search to find what I cannot or will not find on my own. This is exactly what TPM facilitates: I identify the presenting emotion; the Spirit identifies the root.

Connecting with Others

Genuine connection with others requires two things that are in tension: enough safety to be honest, and enough accountability to be corrected. The container protocol (Exploration 6) is the practical implementation of the safety side. The community law (Exploration 7) is the practical implementation of the accountability side.

What I have seen in the Band of Brothers work is that men who are genuinely connected with at least a few other men who know their story are measurably more able to hear God, more resilient under pressure, and more fruitful in their mission than men who are doing the journey alone. This is not a sociological observation; it is a spiritual law. We are designed for community. Isolation is not just uncomfortable; it is a condition that degrades spiritual hearing.

Eccl. 4:12 (ESV)

"And though a man might prevail against one who is alone, two will withstand him—a threefold cord is not quickly broken."

Connecting with God

This is the center of everything — but it comes third in the sequence for a reason. Connecting with Self and with Others clears the ground. A man who has not done honest self-examination and does not have at least one person who knows his actual interior life tends to perform his connection with God rather than living it. The performance looks like a genuine connection, but does not bear the scriptural harvest fullness.

The "Any Doubts?" process (more fully developed in Exploration 7) is designed to address the gap between professed belief and actual trust. The premise is that I may be saying I believe a scripture while simultaneously holding a doubt about it that I have never named or examined. Until that doubt is named and brought to the Spirit, it operates as an underground brake on the faith that scripture should produce.

ELDREDGE CONNECTION — The Question at the Center: John Eldredge argues in *Wild at Heart* (2001, pp. 46–52) that every man carries a core question — most often some version of *Do I have what it takes?* — and that this question is the primary target of both the wound and the enemy's long campaign against the heart. The God-Connect is the only place that question gets a final answer, because the Father is the only one with the authority to give it.

This maps precisely onto what I observe in Band of Brothers work. A man can connect with Self and connect with Others and still find that the God-Connect remains strangely formal — correct, even sincere, but not settled in the way the sequence requires before Mission becomes sustainable. When I probe that flatness, I almost always find an unanswered question underneath: something the man has never actually brought to the Father directly, because bringing it feels too risky, or because he doesn't really believe the Father will answer it, or because he has answered it himself (negatively) and stopped asking.

The practical work of the God-Connect includes exactly this: naming the question out loud — in prayer, in community — and then sitting with the Father long enough to hear His specific answer to it. Not the doctrinal answer (which the man already knows). The personal answer. Isaiah 43:1 is the template: I have called you by name, you are mine. That is the Father answering the question — not in a category, but to a person.

Eldredge's *Waking the Dead* (2003, pp. 37–50) adds the complementary point: the enemy's strategy is not primarily to prevent this conversation from happening but to convince the man that if he brings the question honestly, what he will hear from the Father is confirmation of the wound's verdict. This is the lie underneath the flatness of many men's prayer lives. The God-Connect work is, at its core, the willingness to bring the question anyway, and to trust that what comes back will be better than the verdict the wound installed.

Connecting with Mission

Mission is not a strategy I adopt; it is something I discover through the first three connects. My Mission is the unique intersection of my gifts, my wounds, my history with God, and the needs of the world around me. Satan tries to wound me in the very place I have been gifted so that I will not live out that gifting. If I am willing to go into that wounding, I can find the gold that the Father has for me. You cannot find it by thinking harder; you find it by knowing yourself, being known by others, and hearing from God what He has prepared for you specifically.

Eph. 2:10 (ESV)

"For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them."

The good works were prepared beforehand. They exist. My job is not to invent them but to discover and walk into them — which requires enough self-knowledge, relational honesty, and spiritual hearing to recognize them when they appear.

Let me add a distinction here that I wish I'd had earlier in my journey, because I wasted a lot of energy not having it. Dmitri Bilgere, who has done significant work in men's formation, describes two kinds of mission: uphill and downhill.

Your uphill mission is what you do. It has a goal, a plan, and measurable steps. "I want to help men get unstuck in their spiritual lives, so I'm going to build a small group process and train facilitators." That's an uphill mission — important, real work, and it requires effort to climb toward. Most of the mission language in Christian circles is uphill language.

Your downhill mission is what you are. It's the effect you have on people simply by being fully present and fully yourself. When you are most aligned with the Spirit and most genuinely who God made you to be, what happens in the room? What do people get to be when you show up that way? That is your downhill mission, and it flows — it doesn't have to be pushed.

I notice this distinction is actually embedded in the passage I've been sitting with for decades: "For we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (Eph. 2:10 ESV). The works were prepared. We walk in them — not strain toward them, not engineer them. Walking in what's already prepared sounds a lot more like downhill than uphill. The uphill work is clearing out the blockages so the downhill becomes possible.

Here's a practical question to sit with, when you are at your most alive and your most genuinely yourself — not performing, not managing your image, just present and open — what do the people around you get to be? What does the room feel like? The answer to that is probably closer to your downhill mission than any mission statement you've labored over. Both matter. But the downhill is

the one that flows from who you are rather than what you do, and it is what sustains the uphill when the climbing gets hard.

One more thing about mission, and this one is uncomfortable enough that I almost left it out. Almost. Every genuine calling has a shadow mission — its exact dark mirror. The shadow mission wastes the same gifts your real mission would deploy, absorbs the same energy, and sends it in the opposite direction. It is where you live when you are not being intentional. And it has a deep emotional charge, which is actually how you can recognize it: when someone describes your shadow mission to you accurately, something in you knows it immediately, even though you have probably never said it out loud.

My calling, for as long as I can remember, has been to help men walk more deeply with God — to take what I've been given and pass it on. My shadow mission, if I'm honest, is to control and manipulate others for my own selfish ends and be recognized as someone who knows things. The gifts are the same. The direction is opposite. One serves; one performs. One builds the kingdom; one builds the resume.

The reason this matters in the context of the Four Connects is that a man who is living his shadow mission can feel like he is living his calling. The energy feels real. The drive feels real. It can take years — and sometimes a good brother who will say the uncomfortable thing — to see the difference.

Here is the test: does the mission go outward, serving people beyond yourself and your immediate circle? Or does it draw inward, collecting people in service of something that ultimately serves you? The real mission goes out. The shadow mission draws in. Both can feel, from the inside, like passion. Ask the brothers who know you well which one they're watching.

The “outward” direction the test asks about needs naming. For some cohort members, mission is shaped by craft — by vocation in the older sense of a calling into specific work that fits the way the Spirit has formed them. For others, mission is shaped by household — by raising and discipling a particular set of children and grandchildren, by ordering a marriage, by the daily work of being a son or daughter to aging parents. For still others, mission is shaped by neighborhood — by becoming present and useful in a third-place community where the Spirit has been preparing relationships. And for some, mission goes outward in the direction the prophets pointed: into the systemic work of justice — into engagement with the poor, the marginalized, the imprisoned, the victims of injustice — into the work Bonhoeffer, King, Day, Romero, Cone, Walker-Barnes, and the long African-American prophetic tradition have done in their generations. The corpus does not develop social-justice formation as a distinct stream and defers to these witnesses for the operational wisdom they carry; what the corpus contributes is the recognition that the Four Connects' Mission discovery may land a cohort member there, and that the first three Connects (Self, Others, God) prepare the disciple to bear that work without being deformed by it. A cohort member sensing a pull toward systemic justice should engage Foster's chapter on the Social Justice stream in *Streams of Living Water*, Bonhoeffer's *The Cost of Discipleship*, King's *Letter from Birmingham Jail*, Day's *The Long Loneliness*, and Cone's *The Cross and the Lynching Tree* as primary witnesses to the tradition's operational shape.

Proposed Law (Structural): Connecting with Self, Others, God, and Mission is a causal sequence with directional dependencies. Each layer creates the conditions for the next. Attempts to connect with God while bypassing honest self-examination and genuine community tend to produce performance rather than transformation. Attempts to find and live a mission without the first three connections tend to produce activity without fruit.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The sequence and its dependencies are confirmed by observation over many years of working with men. The specific mechanisms are still being developed — this is the area where the community dimension of IJH testing will be most valuable.*

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: *The causal sequence (Self → Others → God → Mission, each layer creating conditions for the next) maps onto SST's soul taxonomy with remarkable precision. Connecting with Self requires at minimum SST soul Level 1 (Awareness of Soul-Disorder) — a person who has not yet honestly named their interior fragmentation cannot connect with self in the sense this law intends. Connecting with Others requires SST soul Level 4.2 (Relational Coherence) as a developmental horizon — the soul-disorder patterns of envy, comparison, manipulation, and withdrawal must be at least partially addressed for genuine community to become possible. Connecting with God requires SST spirit Stage 2+ (Learning to Follow the Spirit) as a developmental prerequisite — not merely the initial regeneration of Stage 1 but the developing discipline of recognizing and following the Spirit's lead. The sequence in this law and the developmental architecture in SST are describing the same reality from different angles: SST explains why the dependencies in this law exist.*

Dave Smith and I have wrapped these four connects into a workshop format, called, surprisingly the Four Connects. This is a six-module introduction to doing heart work and has a good impact on people who have experienced it. The end of the workshop is an invitation to join a Fellowship of the Heart community/small group for ongoing development in internalizing hearing and obeying God.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 6 — TOOLS

Sixth Exploration: The Tool Map — Matching the Right Tool to the Right Blockage

Why the Map Matters

I have a long list of tools and processes that I have found effective in various contexts. The list includes GRH, TPM, Inner Healing in the Payne/Bennett tradition, shadow work, voice dialogue, psychodrama, the Wild at Heart materials, Warrior Monk processes, and more. The list is not the problem. The problem is that without a map showing which tool addresses which blockage type, I end up applying tools at random — and a well-intentioned but wrong tool can make things worse. GRH and TPM have explicit mappings of tools, which are helpful. What follows is my mapping as I have used the tools.

The diagnostic framework from Part I gives us the map. Here is how I currently understand the tool-to-blockage correspondence:

For Grief Knots: Naming and Completing

The primary tool is the Grief Recovery Handbook process. Its key contribution is the Loss Graph — a systematic identification of the losses in my life with ongoing emotional impact. Most people underestimate how many forms of loss they are carrying, because we have a culturally narrow definition of grief (death of a loved one) that excludes losses from divorce, betrayal, career failure, loss of health, loss of a dream, and dozens of other forms. The GRH process names them all and creates specific "completion letters", the unfinished communications that need to be said.

The spiritual completion of GRH work happens through TPM: I bring the named grief to the Lord in the specific memory context and invite Him to speak. His truth about the loss, about the person lost, about what comes next — this is what releases the grief knot. The GRH can identify what needs to be brought; TPM can be the point of access through which the Spirit completes the work.

For Shame Knots: Recovering the Gold

The primary tool is the Gold and Shadow work from the Band of Brothers material. The shadow is the disowned, ashamed part of the self — the part I have hidden because I believe it is too broken, too weak, too dark to be acceptable. The gold is the God-given strength that got buried with that part of myself. The Shadow Mission work asks: if my God-given strength were taken and twisted in the worst possible direction, what would that look like? The answer reveals both the deepest threat and the deepest gift.

The inner healing complement: once the shadow has been named, I bring it to the Lord in prayer. The specific lie at the root of the shame is identified. The Spirit speaks truth. The gold is recovered. The ashamed part is integrated rather than kept hidden, and in the integration, it loses its power to drain me.

For Fear Knots: The Somatic Entry

Fear knots require a different entry point. Because the fear response is physically expressed, the somatic entry — breath work, progressive relaxation, body awareness — should come first to bring

the nervous system out of the threat-response state before cognitive or spiritual approaches can reach the root. The Garden of Your Heart exercise (described in Exploration 7) serves this function: the guided relaxation creates a physiological opening before the Spirit-encounter is invited. Many other exercises, classic breathing exercises, for example, can work here.

Once the somatic entry has created access, the TPM sequence applies: the fear emotion leads to the originating memory; the memory reveals the lie ("I am not safe," "God cannot be trusted," "I am alone"); the Spirit speaks the truth. The specific truth about God's presence and power in the specific feared situation is what releases the fear knot. Not generic reassurance — specific truth for this specific fear.

For Anger Knots: Naming Before Releasing

Anger knots require the injustice to be named honestly before forgiveness can be genuine. Attempting to forgive before naming the full weight of the wrong produces suppression, not release. The sequence: I name what was done, I acknowledge what it cost me, I acknowledge my anger at it, and then — and only then — I bring it to the Lord and release my claim to be the one who settles the score.

The psychodrama and voice dialogue tools are useful here because they provide a safe structure for expressing and witnessing anger before it is released. A man who has never been able to say out loud, in a safe container, "what you did to me was wrong, and it cost me this and this and this" — that man cannot fully release the anger because it has never been fully named. The speaking is part of the completion.

For Sin Knots: Confession and Community

As established in Exploration 4, the tool for sin blockage is confession — specific, owned, without self-justification. The community complement is James 5:16 — confessing to one another in a safe container. The container protocol from Exploration 8 is the preparation for this kind of confession to be possible.

Proposed Law (Tool Application): Matching the right tool to the right blockage is itself a skill requiring discernment, and the Tool Map operates along three orthogonal dimensions, not one. The blockage-type dimension names what is blocked: grief knots respond to naming and completing (GRH → TPM); shame knots respond to shadow recovery and identity truth (Gold/Shadow → Inner Healing); fear knots respond to somatic entry followed by specific truth (Relaxation → TPM); anger knots respond to full naming before release (Psychodrama/Voice Dialogue → Forgiveness prayer); sin knots respond to confession (V2.Exp4); idol knots — added to the taxonomy in v5_6_o_6 to mirror V1.FL.III — respond to identification of the functional savior (Keller's diagnostic questions: what do I look to for ultimate security, meaning, or identity?), explicit renunciation (A25 Breaking the Contracts is the canonical ritual-corporate form, applied to the throne-occupant rather than to an interior agreement), and Spirit-led re-enthronement of Christ (Col. 3:1–4 as the orientational anchor); the distinguishing diagnostic for an idol knot is that the downstream knots (grief, shame, fear, anger, sin) re-form across multiple cycles of individual clearing because the throne-occupant continues producing them. The access-mode dimension names how the blockage is accessed: verbal/visual entry is the default mode the named protocols above presuppose; somatic/kinesthetic entry (B14 Kinesthetic Metaphor) is canonical operational form for body-led processors and for moments when verbal/visual entry has gone flat; imaginative-figure entry (B11 Ideal Support Figure) is canonical

operational form for grief-knots and tender shame-knots reachable through reparenting work; ritual-corporate entry (A25 Breaking the Contracts is paradigmatic) is canonical operational form when standing interior agreements bind across multiple knot-types. The governing-axis dimension names what governs from upstream: the image-of-God axis (A24 Blessing Receiving with God-split is the canonical instance) governs what kind of healing the blockage can receive — when a shaming-voice-as-idol has substituted itself for the Lord's voice, the participant cannot hear the Lord's actual blessing across any of the blockage-types until the substitution is named; the contract / agreement axis (A25 Breaking the Contracts is the canonical instance; V2.Exp2C Standing Interior Agreements supplies the diagnostic-claim altitude upstream) governs what binds the blockages downstream — standing interior agreements produce knots across multiple blockage-types and require their own renunciation work, distinct from work on the downstream knots they produce; the heart-throne axis (V1.FL.III supplies the law-level altitude; the diagnostic and operational form is the idol-knot work added to the blockage-type dimension above) governs what is enthroned at the heart's center — when something other than Christ has been enthroned, the downstream knots re-form even after individual clearing because the throne-occupant continues producing them; Companion discernment of the heart-throne axis often surfaces what makes a participant's otherwise-well-cleared knot pattern stubbornly recur. The three dimensions operate together: any specific protocol's deployment requires the Companion's discernment of all three dimensions for the participant's specific situation — what is blocked (blockage-type), how the participant accesses processing (access-mode), and what governs from upstream (governing-axis). In all deployments, the Holy Spirit is the agent of release; the preparatory conditions are the tools.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The tool-to-type mapping is the author's current best working hypothesis, based on observation. The boundaries are not clean — most knots have multiple types mixed together, and the right entry point for a given person in a given moment requires discernment that cannot be fully systematized. This is where the community of practitioners does its most important testing work. The three-dimensional structure surfaced in the synthesis pass (May 13, 2026) names what the practice has been carrying implicitly; the operational confidence is unchanged by making the dimensions explicit, though the discoverability of the Map's structure improves substantially.*

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The discernment needed to match the right tool to the correct blockage type is itself a formation-level competency — not a skill that can be taught cognitively and applied mechanically. HFT's Affective Level 3 is the threshold: a person operating at Level 1–2 (compliance, attendance, following a curriculum) will tend to use tools in the order the curriculum presents rather than in the order the Spirit is guiding. MSFIG emphasizes this in its section on small group leadership: a leader cannot help a group grow into Srage 3+ formation if they themselves operate at Level 1/2. The same limitation applies — the discernment this law requires is a Srage 4 competency (Organization: integrating what one has learned about the Spirit's work into a coherent framework for analyzing specific situations). This is not a critique of beginners; it's an honest reflection of the developmental path the work demands.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 6A — PASTORAL-ANTHROPOLOGICAL LAW

Sixth Exploration (A): The Image-Bearing Dignity of the Wronger

The Operational Split and Its Limit

Several of the corpus's anger-work protocols deploy a *therapeutic split*: the wrongdoer the participant is working to forgive is provisionally divided into the wounding-behavior figure and the loving-behavior figure, so the participant can feel the anger toward the wounding figure honestly, without violating their loyalty to the actual person or denying the actual person's personhood. A12 Splitting a Role is the canonical instance; many of the Tell-Show-Release family protocols (A18–A20), and the BoB Healing and Forgiveness work (A17), use a version of the same move.

The split works because it solves a specific problem: most participants cannot direct full anger at someone they also love and to whom they are obligated. The unsplit anger turns inward and becomes shame, or sideways and becomes corrosive resentment, or never surfaces at all. The split gives the anger a target it can be directed at without the participant having to choose between feeling the anger and honoring the bond.

But the split has a sharp limit, which Exploration 6A names. **The split is operational, not ontological.** It is a tool for accessing the anger; it is not a description of who the wrongdoer actually is. The wrongdoer is, ontologically, one person — an image-bearer whose dignity the formation work must preserve throughout. The participant is not granted, by virtue of having been wounded, permission to undo the wrongdoer's personhood. The clearing work is *not* permission to dehumanize.

What This Discipline Asks of the Companion

The Companion's discipline at the close of any work that has used the split is to bring the wrongdoer back together as the actual person. The downstream forgiveness work (Exploration 6B) re-integrates the wronger as the actual person to be forgiven, not as the split-off bad figure the anger work was directed at. Without this re-integration, the participant walks out of the session having done beautiful anger work and an entirely separate, half-completed forgiveness work — released from the anger toward the split-off figure but still entangled with the actual person on terms the work was supposed to address.

Proposed Law (Pastoral-Anthropological): Every person, including the wrongdoer the participant is working to forgive, is an image-bearer whose dignity the formation work must preserve. The therapeutic move of distinguishing wounding behavior from loving behavior is operational, not ontological — it serves the participant's capacity to feel the anger honestly without violating loyalty or denying the wrongdoer's personhood. Downstream forgiveness work re-integrates the wronger as the actual person to be forgiven, not as the split-off bad figure the anger work was directed at.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *Among the most settled implicit moves in the corpus. The image-of-God doctrine (Gen 1:26–27; Jas 3:9; Matt 5:44–45; Luke 15:20 — the prodigal's father embraces the integrated returning son) is among the most ecumenically settled, convergent across all four streams of the tradition we draw from. Possibly the cleanest single claim added in the Council Batch 1 acceptance (May 11, 2026): strongest epistemic class — directly stated in scripture plus operational pattern — and minimal Council deliberation. Pairs with Exploration 6B as the coupled pair governing all wronger-figure therapeutic work.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V1.Ax2 (the givenness of the image-of-God); V1.FL.V (Reciprocal Forgiveness — the law-level account of forgiveness beneath which this pastoral-anthropological claim sits); V2.Exp1B (wound/sin distinction precedes the integration discipline). Downstream: V2.Exp6 (Tool Map anger-knot subsection operates under this discipline); V2.Exp6B (the paired forgiveness claim); V2.Exp6C (sibling structural-law within the V2.Exp6 cluster — synthesis pass May 13, 2026). Canonical protocol-level instances in Vol 5 Part VI: A24 Blessing Receiving with God-split; A25 Breaking the Contracts.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 6B — PASTORAL-ANTHROPOLOGICAL LAW

Sixth Exploration (B): Forgiveness as Re-integration of the Wronger

The Form Forgiveness Takes

If Exploration 6A names the discipline of preserving the wronger's personhood through the anger work, this Exploration names the form forgiveness itself takes once the anger work has done its work. The two claims travel together as a coupled pair, and they prevent a particular failure mode the corpus has watched produce repeatedly across two decades of pastoral work: men who do beautiful, complete anger work in a session and walk out with their forgiveness work undone — still resolving their anger at *bad dad* while the actual father is somewhere else entirely, unforgiven and unaddressed.

The corrective form is the one scripture itself models. Matthew 18:21–35's unforgiving-servant parable addresses the whole person. Ephesians 4:32's *as God in Christ forgave you* invokes a divine pattern that forgives the integrated person — the one the gospel justifies is not split into wounding-self and loving-self for the purposes of the justification; the gospel addresses the whole. Luke 15:20's prodigal's father embraces the integrated returning son rather than the just-the-good-parts version. Luke 23:34's *Father, forgive them* — *them* is the actual persons, not an abstraction.

What the Companion Has to Do

The Companion's discipline is therefore not just to use the therapeutic split for the anger work but to *put the person back together for the forgiveness*. This is operationally specific: the closing of any work that has used the split includes a re-integration move where the wronger is named again as the whole person, the anger work's split-off figures are released, and the forgiveness work (whether in the same session or in a later cycle) operates on the integrated person.

The failure mode is not a moral defect; it is a sequencing failure that the corpus's anger-work protocols can produce when the closing move is omitted or rushed. Stating the coupled pair explicitly — 6A governs the anger-with-split, 6B governs the forgiveness-after-re-integration — gives the Companion a clean canonical reference for the close of any anger-work session. Forgiveness work that operates only on the split-off bad figure leaves the relationship unresolved and produces release-without-reconciliation, which is half the work.

Proposed Law (Pastoral-Anthropological): Forgiveness in Christian formation is forgiveness of the integrated person. Therapeutic operations that split the wronger into wounding-behavior and loving-behavior figures are tools for accessing the anger honestly; they are not the form forgiveness itself takes. After the anger work has done its work, the forgiveness work re-integrates: the actual person, image-bearing and whole, is the one to be forgiven. Forgiveness work that operates only on the split-off bad figure leaves the relationship unresolved and produces release-without-reconciliation, which is half the work. The Companion's discipline is to use the therapeutic split as a tool for the anger and to put the person back together for the forgiveness.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *The basic claim is convergent across the four streams of the tradition. The specific formulation was tested in Council deliberation to confirm it does not foreclose on the Reformed-Evangelical unilateral-interior-act framing nor under-state the sacramental-tradition reconciliation move.*

The pairing with Exploration 6A gives the coupled-pair structure governing all wronger-figure therapeutic work. Council-accepted as drafted on May 12, 2026 (Theological Assumptions Registry, Batch 2, Claim 4).

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V1.Ax2; V1.FL.V (Reciprocal Forgiveness — the law-level account of forgiveness beneath which the integration form of forgiveness sits); V2.Exp6A (the paired upstream claim); V2.Exp1B (wound/sin distinction grounds the integration discipline). Downstream: V2.Exp6 (Tool Map anger-knot subsection); V2.Exp6C (sibling structural-law in the V2.Exp6 cluster); V2.Exp7. Canonical operational instances in Vol 5 Part VI: A12 Splitting a Role (originating instance), A1 MKP Clearing, A17 BoB Healing and Forgiveness, A18–A20 Tell-Show Release family, A23 BoB Shadow and Projections, A24 Blessing Receiving, A25 Breaking the Contracts.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 6C — STRUCTURAL LAW

Sixth Exploration (C): The Discernment-from-Outside-the-Frame Law

A Discipline Operating at Five Altitudes

When I look across the protocols the corpus has developed — the Triangle facilitation move (A10), the Heart Prayer Time step 2 (*Father, where are You?*, B18), the Companion-as-witness discipline (the third paragraph of the refined Exploration 8 below), the source-reversal canonical series (eleven canonical instances now, across closing-affirmations, corporate-mission, embodied-resonance, blessing rounds, renunciation in Jesus's name, attending-and-choosing-in-active-communion, and other moves), and the refined V1.Exp2 (deliberate attending-and-choosing as the spirit's faculty of stepping outside System-1 default into deliberate processing) — I notice the same structural move operating at every altitude. The participant steps outside the immediate frame to receive what is true from outside it. The Companion holds the room without imposing the Companion's interpretation. The protocol locates agency at the Lord's level rather than at the participant's. The discipline is, in all five places, the same discipline.

The synthesis pass of May 13, 2026 named what I had not named at the canonical-claim altitude before: this is a structural law that governs across the altitudes. Discernment of what is true requires stepping outside the immediate frame to receive what is true from outside. The discipline is structurally constitutive of the corpus's hearing, healing, and formation work; without it, the work operates from inside whatever default frame the participant brings — which is precisely what the corpus's broader anthropology names as the System-1 / false-self / inside-the-knot starting position.

What This Does at the Companion-Stance Level

The Companion's structural stance in any deployment of the Tool Map (Exploration 6) operates under this law. The Companion's discernment about *which tool to deploy and how to deploy it* requires the same from-outside-the-frame stance that the deployed tool will then help the participant practice. A Companion who selects a tool from inside the participant's frame — receiving the participant's account of the situation as the operational map — has already foreclosed on the work the tool was supposed to do. The Companion's discernment must operate from outside the participant's frame, in the Lord's, for the tool-selection itself to be sound.

This is not a new claim about agency — it is the same claim the corpus has carried in the source-reversal canonical series and in the V1.Exp2 anthropology, named explicitly at the level where it governs the operational discipline that makes the rest of the volume's work possible. The Christian tradition has names for this stance from its own resources: the Ignatian discipline of noticing, the Pauline *transformed-by-the-renewal-of-your-mind* discipline (Rom 12:2), the apophatic stance from the contemplative tradition.

Proposed Law (Structural): Discernment of what is true requires stepping outside the immediate frame to receive what is true from outside. The discipline operates across multiple altitudes: at the facilitation-move altitude (A10 Triangle pulls the participant out of the scene to a discernment position); at the prayer-discipline altitude (B18 step 2 *Father, where are You?* steps the participant outside their own viewpoint to receive Christ's); at the Companion-as-witness altitude (Exploration 8 refined paragraph 3 holds the room without imposing the Companion's interpretation); at the source-reversal altitude (the Spirit-mediation framing

locates agency at the Lord's level rather than at the participant's, across the eleven canonical instances of the source-reversal canonical series); at the theological-anthropology altitude (V1.Exp2 refined names the spirit's faculty of stepping outside System-1 default into deliberate attending-and-choosing). The discipline is structurally constitutive of the corpus's hearing, healing, and formation work; without it, the work operates from inside whatever default frame the participant brings. The Companion's structural stance in any deployment of the Tool Map operates under this law; the Companion's discernment about which tool to deploy and how to deploy it requires the same from-outside-the-frame stance that the deployed tool will then help the participant practice.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The discipline operates explicitly across five distinct altitudes of canonical practice; the Reasonably Inferred confidence reflects the operational pattern being well-established across the corpus's canonical practice. The synthesis-pass canonization (May 13, 2026) names the structural law that has been operating implicitly throughout; the canonization makes the law explicit without adding new substantive theological content. The law is theologically clean and convergent with multiple Christian-traditional disciplines (Ignatian noticing; the apophatic contemplative stance; the Pauline transformed-mind tradition).*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V1.Exp1 (hearing channel — what the discipline operationalizes); V1.Exp2 refined (deliberate attending-and-choosing); V2.Expo (tool import discipline). Downstream: V2.Exp6 (the law operates throughout the Map's deployment); V2.Exp7; V2.Exp7A; V2.Exp8 refined; V2.Exp8B. Canonical instances in Vol 5 Part VI: A10 Triangle (facilitation-move altitude), B18 Heart Prayer Time step 2 (prayer-discipline altitude).

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 7 — OPERATIONAL

Seventh Exploration: Hearing with Understanding — The Experiential Processes



The Goal of Part II

All the clearing work in Explorations 1 through 6 is in service of one thing: a heart that is open enough to hear. But hearing is also a skill — a faculty that develops with practice, that requires specific exercises to grow, and that can remain underdeveloped even in a person whose channel is relatively clear. This exploration describes the primary practices for developing the hearing faculty itself.

A Doctrinal Frame Before the Practices

Before describing the specific hearing practices in this chapter, a doctrinal frame needs to sit in place — for the participant whose hearing is developing and for the Companion whose discernment is forming.

There are two senses of revelation in the New Testament, and naming the distinction matters here. First, canonical revelation: the inspired writings that constitute scripture, breathed out by God (2 Tim. 3:16–17), spoken once for all in these last days through the Son (Heb. 1:1–2), entrusted to the saints (Jude 3), to which nothing is to be added and from which nothing is to be taken (Deut. 4:2; Rev. 22:18–19). The canon is closed. Second, operational hearing — what the Spirit speaks today to the believer for specific application, direction, the next obedience. This kind of hearing is real and taught throughout the New Testament (John 16:13; Acts 8:29; Acts 13:2; 1 Cor. 14:3), and it is the territory of this chapter’s practices. But it is non-canonical in every sense. What the Spirit speaks today must be tested against the canon (1 John 4:1; 1 Thess. 5:20–21), is never a license to add to or alter what scripture has established, and is authoritative only within the scope of what scripture already teaches. Wayne Grudem’s articulation of this distinction in *The Gift of Prophecy in the New Testament and Today* is one of the clearer contemporary statements; the underlying doctrine is older and broadly held.

This pairs with the refinement at the front of Vol 1 in v5_6_o_14 (“A Note on the Inclusion Criteria”), which names that the Spirit’s witness operates through and in confirmation of scripture, never as an independent epistemic source that could in principle validate something scripture has not established. The hearing this chapter teaches operates inside the same boundary. The “Any Doubts?” process, the Garden of Your Heart exercise, the Affective Taxonomy progression, the rhema-receiving work in TPM — every practice that follows assumes the participant is hearing in application of, and in confirmation of, the canon. A Companion or participant who finds the voice the discernment work has identified as the Spirit’s saying something that contradicts scripture has

discerned wrongly; the voice is not the Spirit's. A participant who comes to think that the operational hearing she is doing in this work adds to the canon has misunderstood what the work is. The Spirit speaks; the canon governs.

Operational hearing is, then, not new revelation. It is the Spirit's ongoing application of revealed truth to the specific believer, the specific moment, the specific obedience. The classical distinction between *logos* (the abiding, written Word) and *rhema* (the specific spoken word that lands in the present moment) — already named in Vol 1's Exploration 1 and recurring throughout this volume — sits inside this canonical frame. The *logos* is canon; the *rhema* is the canonical truth's specific landing in the believer's life. The two are not parallel sources of authority; the *rhema* is the application of the *logos*.

The Adversary at the Moment of Reception

There is a third thing the participant and Companion both need named before the practices begin, alongside the goal of Part II and the doctrinal frame. The Adversary is operationally present at the moment of reception.

The locus classicus is the parable of the sower. Mark 4:14–15 (ESV): “The sower sows the word. And these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them.” This is not metaphor for the moralist's distractibility. It is a description of the enemy's specific tactic at the precise moment when scripture is being received. The word lands; before it can take root, it is taken away. Paul names the same dynamic in 2 Cor. 4:4 (ESV) — “the god of this world has blinded the minds of unbelievers” — and in 2 Cor. 11:3 (ESV) — “I am afraid that as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning, your thoughts will be led astray from a sincere and pure devotion to Christ.”

Operationally, this shows up in specific ways the participant doing the hearing work in this chapter will recognize. The sudden intrusion of an unrelated thought at the moment a scripture begins to register. The heaviness or sleepiness that descends precisely when sustained attention to the Word is required. The immediate counter-narrative (“but for you it's different...”) that meets the truth before the truth can land. The urgent-feeling distraction that pulls the participant out of the moment of reception. Companions who have worked with participants long enough will know the pattern; participants who name the pattern stop being managed by it.

The response is operationally specific. Name the interference (not theatrically, but as observation: that thought just now is taking the word away). Resist (Jas. 4:7, ESV: “Resist the devil, and he will flee from you”). Return to the scripture; receive it again. Persist. The container conditions named in Exploration 8 (Safe, Present, Clear, Intentional) reduce the surface area the Adversary operates on; the discernment of voices in Exploration 7A names what kind of voice is opposing the reception; the doctrinal frame above governs what counts as a valid landing. Together, these disciplines do not eliminate the enemy's interference — that interference is constitutive of the war the disciple is in — but they reduce its operational success and refuse it the participant's territory. This is named more fully in V2.Exp2B (the Adversary's Role); the relevance here is operational. Every hearing practice in this chapter is being done in territory the enemy contests, and the participant should know that going in.

The "Any Doubts?" Process

This is one of the most powerful hearing-development exercises I know, because it targets the specific mechanism by which intellectual assent blocks genuine trust. I may be saying I believe a scripture — “God is good,” “I am loved,” “He will provide” — while simultaneously holding a doubt about it that

I have never examined. That doubt is a below-the-surface brake on the faith that scripture should produce.

The process: a facilitator reads a scripture to the person processing. The person is invited to close their eyes, receive the scripture, and notice any resistance, tension, or doubt that arises. The facilitator asks: "Any doubts?" If yes, the person names the doubt. The facilitator invites them to exaggerate the doubt — make it bigger, louder, more present. Then: "What feeling do you experience with that doubt?" The person names the feeling and dwells in it until they reach the peak of the emotion. Then the scripture is read again. The cycle repeats until the doubt is gone and the scripture can be received without resistance.

What is happening theologically: the doubt is an emotional knot attached to a specific truth-claim. By bringing it fully into awareness rather than suppressing it, I give the Spirit access to it. The exaggeration step is counterintuitive but important — it moves the doubt from a background hum to a foreground reality that can be addressed. The repeated reading of the scripture after the emotional peak creates the conditions for the Spirit to speak the truth of that specific scripture into the specific place where the doubt was held.

Mark 9:24 (ESV)

"Immediately the father of the child cried out and said, 'I believe; help my unbelief!'"

This is the model. The father did not pretend that the unbelief was not there. He named it, brought it to Jesus, and asked for help with it. That is the "Any Doubts?" process in one sentence. The unbelief that is named and brought to Jesus is the unbelief that can be released. The unbelief that is suppressed out of spiritual performance pressure continues to operate as a brake.

A word about the facilitator's interior job across all of these processes, because I have seen facilitation succeed and fail on exactly this point. Dave Smith describes it well: the facilitator in a process is listening to two voices at the same time. One is the man in front of him — his words, his body language, where the energy is high and where it goes flat. The other is the Holy Spirit — the quiet prompting that says "stay here," or "ask him about that," or "just wait." The facilitator who is only tracking the man will follow him wherever he goes, including down the well-worn detours that feel productive but don't reach the root. The facilitator who is only listening inward, without genuine attention to the man in front of him, gives beautiful answers to questions nobody asked.

The dual listening is itself an act of faith on the facilitator's part. It requires staying genuinely open to hearing something unplanned, which means not coming in with a fixed agenda about where the session needs to go. The Word → Hearing → Faith chain applies to the facilitator just as much as to the person being facilitated. He is, in real terms, in the same position: dependent on the Spirit to speak, and dependent on his own willingness to hear it.

This is why the container conditions matter as much for the facilitator as for anyone else in the room. If he is carrying unaddressed material or has a strong preference about the outcome, his hearing is degraded before the work begins. He will hear what he expects or what he wants, not what the Spirit is actually saying. Getting clear before facilitating is not a courtesy — it is the prerequisite.

The Garden of Your Heart

This exercise is both a hearing practice and a diagnostic tool. It creates a structured encounter with the Holy Spirit in the interior space of the heart. Here is the full process:

The Garden of Your Heart — Full Process

1. Prepare: Have paper and pen available. Create an environment where participants can be genuinely relaxed and undistracted.

2. Relax: Guide participants through progressive relaxation, starting at the toes and working upward. The goal is not sleep but a present, alert, quiet state. Breath meditation — focused attention on the in-and-out of the breath — helps anchor the present moment.
3. Picture: Ask participants to picture their heart as a garden. Let this sit for several minutes. Whatever appears — wild, overgrown, cultivated, barren, seasonal — is information. There is no wrong garden.
4. Record: Invite participants back to the present moment to record what they saw, heard, smelled, or felt in the garden. The specific sensory details matter; they often carry diagnostic meaning.
5. Invite: Return to the garden in the same relaxed state. This time, invite Jesus into the garden. Suggest they ask Him to do or say whatever He wants to. Let this sit for several minutes.
6. Record again: Return to the present moment and record what happened — what Jesus said or did, where He went, what He touched, what He left unchanged.
7. Share (optional): In a group context, invite anyone who wants to share their experience. The sharing itself often opens additional revelation.

I have run this exercise dozens of times with different groups of men, and the consistency of the results is one reason my confidence in it is relatively high. The garden consistently reveals something the person did not consciously know about their interior state. Jesus' interaction with the garden is almost always specific, personal, and unexpected. The element of surprise is itself a sign that the Spirit is doing something beyond the person's projections. I always participate at the same time and have something new and developmental happen in each iteration. I understand this is my heart developing and changing. Such an encouragement when I really don't notice any changes cognitively.

The Footprints of God Exercise

This is a backward-looking hearing exercise: instead of asking "what is God saying now?" it asks "where can I see God's hand in my life story looking backward?" This is important because the ability to recognize God's activity in the past trains the pattern-recognition faculty that learns to see His activity in the present.

The questions: Where were the turning points in my life that I did not engineer? What were the gifts I did not ask for that arrived at exactly the right moment? Where did something that seemed like a disaster turn into something good? Where was I protected from something I did not know was threatening me? The answers to these questions are a map of God's personal attention to my specific life. And a person who can see that map tends to have an easier time trusting that the same attention is present now.

Lam. 3:22-23 (ESV)

"The steadfast love of the Lord never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

Looking backward at the footprints is how this truth moves from a doctrine I assent to into a personal reality I have seen. The faithfulness is not abstract; it has specific instances in my specific story.

PROAPT: The Systematic Hearing of Scripture

A theological question worth addressing directly: what is the relationship between what I am calling 'personal hearing' in this framework and the spiritual gifts Paul describes in 1 Corinthians 12–14? Grudem's treatment in *The Gift of Prophecy* is helpful here. He distinguishes between Old Testament prophecy — authoritative, infallible, 'Thus says the Lord' — and New Testament congregational prophecy, which he describes as Spirit-prompted impressions received and shared in community, subject to testing and weighing rather than immediate acceptance. On Grudem's account, this kind

of receptive hearing is not a specialized gift reserved for a few; it is the normal Spirit-filled life available to every believer in varying degrees of clarity and frequency. I believe PROAPT's hearing practice operates in this register: not as the reception of new authoritative revelation alongside scripture, but as the Spirit's personal application of scriptural truth to the specific person in the specific moment. Understanding this prevents two errors: the error of treating personal impressions as authoritative pronouncements, and the error of dismissing the possibility of personal Spirit-speech as something the New Testament no longer supports.

Carolyn and I were taught this at Truro Church in the 1980s and it has stayed with me as one of the most systematic approaches to developing the hearing faculty through scripture study, in particular in a small group setting. The acronym is: Pray, Read, Observe, Apply, Pray again, Tell.

- **Pray:** Before reading, invite the Spirit to speak. This is not a formality; it is the acknowledgment that I am approaching the Word as someone who expects to hear from it, not merely to extract information from it.
- **Read:** Read the passage. Not to analyze it immediately — just to receive it. Let it land.
- **Observe:** What do I actually notice? What stands out? What is strange or unexpected? What do I not understand? Honest observation precedes interpretation.
- **Apply:** What does this mean for me specifically, today, in my specific situation? This is where the *logos* becomes *rhema* — where the general word of scripture becomes a specific word to me. (For the important caution about how I am using the *rhema/logos* distinction — functionally rather than lexically — see Vol 1, Exploration 1.)
- **Pray again:** Bring the application to God. Tell Him what you heard, what you are willing to do, what you are struggling to be willing to do. This is where the obedience channel opens.
- **Tell:** Share what you heard with someone — a spouse, a brother, a trusted friend. The speaking of it solidifies it and creates accountability.

The Tell step is the one most often omitted and the one most important for long-term development. A word heard and spoken to another person has a different staying power than a word heard and kept private. The speaking is an act of faith that the word was real.

The Hearing Journey as Affective Taxonomy: A Formal Map

Jesus said something remarkable in explaining the Sower parable to His disciples: “Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables?” (Mark 4:13). He was identifying it as the meta-discipline — the foundational pattern that unlocks all the others. If that is right, then having a formal map of the soil progression matters more than we usually recognize.

The Affective Taxonomy (Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, 1964) provides that formal map. My doctoral research in Christian education has proposed this taxonomy as a defensible framework for describing the observable human side of spiritual formation in the area of hearing and obeying. The compressed research paper is here: [A Model of Spiritual Formation for Individuals and Small Groups \(MSFIG\) - A Model of Spiritual Formation for Individuals and Small Groups v2.docx](#)

Here, in summary, is how the individual stages apply to a person's journey in learning to hear and obey God:

Level 1 — Receiving

Bare awareness; willingness to attend. A person at this level is willing to show up, listen, read the passage, and participate at a surface level. Motivation is entirely external. They are at a bible study because someone invited them, or because it fits their schedule, not because they have yet found

value in the Word itself. This is the hard path that is on the verge of becoming receptive soil. The diagnostic indicator: they attend but rarely initiate. They listen but rarely bring anything from their own reflection.

Level 2 — Responding

Active engagement; following through when prompted. The Level 2 person participates in discussion, completes assigned readings, and prays when the group prays. But the motivation is still largely external — social expectations, accountability, and the group's rhythm. Rocky soil territory. The roots are beginning to form, but they have not yet gone deep enough to produce fruit in private, unsupported contexts. The diagnostic indicator: active in the group context, but the hearing and praying largely stop when the external structure stops.

Level 3 — Valuing (The Critical Transition)

This is the transition from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation — the shift from “I hear God’s word because the group expects it” to “I hear God’s word because I have discovered that it is worth my time and is changing my life.” A Level 3 person reads scripture privately, not because a study guide requires it. They pray on their own. They bring a genuine question to the group, not a curriculum question. This is the floor of good soil, the 30-fold harvest. The diagnostic indicator: consistent private practice, not just group practice.

Level 4 — Organization

The word is integrated into a coherent value system. Faith now informs vocation, finances, relationships, and daily decisions in a systemic way. A Level 4 person brings their real decisions to God and to the group for genuine discernment, not just prayer support. They are developing what Barna (2003) calls a biblical worldview — not as an intellectual construct but as a governing framework for every domain. The 60-fold harvest. The diagnostic indicator: consistent behavioral evidence in multiple life domains that the Word is governing, not just informing.

Level 5 — Characterization

Hearing and obeying have determined and controlled behavior for so long that they have become a defining characteristic of the person’s identity. They do not deliberate about whether to obey; they obey as a matter of who they are. The Word has become, as Dallas Willard puts it, not just something they study but the medium through which they live. This is the 100-fold harvest, the mind of Christ. The diagnostic indicator: others describe them primarily in terms of their Christlikeness — it is the first thing you notice about them.

Two cautions: First, progress through these levels is not linear. A Level 4 person who suffers a significant loss may appear to regress to Level 1 or 2 — asking fundamental questions about who God is, why He would allow such a thing. This is not regression; it is what Walter Brueggemann calls the disorientation phase of a deeper orientation. Saint John of the Cross describes this as the Dark Night of the Soul: the person is not losing faith but being stripped of a smaller faith so that a larger one can be formed. The apparent regression is the soil being broken up more deeply so that the roots can go deeper. The external observer who does not understand this will apply Level 1-2 remedies to a person who is actually on the threshold of Level 5.

Second, the Spirit is not constrained by this taxonomy. Sudden, permanent changes of heart are well attested throughout scripture and church history. The taxonomy describes the normal developmental path; the Spirit reserves the right to bypass it.

The Small Group as a Hearing Community: A Parallel Taxonomy

The same five levels apply to a small group as a collective, not just to an individual. Paul's instruction assumes this: "When you come together, each one has a hymn, a lesson, a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation. Let all things be done for building up" (1 Cor. 14:26). A group can be at Level 1 (the leader hears and distributes to passive recipients) or at Level 5 (the group's culture of hearing and obeying has become so characteristic that every member it has formed now carries that culture into the next community they enter). The five levels for a group:

- Group Level 1: Hearing is mediated through the leader. Members listen. Prayer requests are informational and seldom personal. The group has not yet developed its own collective receptivity.
- Group Level 2: Members begin contributing. The leader asks genuine questions, not curriculum questions. Members build on each other. The dynamics of "each one has" begin to appear.
- Group Level 3: The group trusts each other enough to bring real decisions, not just prayer requests. Corporate listening prayer becomes a practice. The group shares what it hears and compares. Convergences are noted and tested.
- Group Level 4: Individual members' hearing is naturally submitted to the group for testing. The group's collective discernment informs individual decisions as a matter of culture, not procedure. The group may hear about itself — its own blind spots and calling.
- Group Level 5: Former members lead new groups that exhibit the same hearing culture, not by following a manual but by having been formed by it. The Level 5 culture is portable. It replicates itself through the people it has formed.

A critical observation: a leader cannot help a group grow to Level 3/4/5 unless the leader has been to at least Level 3 (Internalization) first. The hearing culture is transmitted by presence and formation, not by curriculum.

Proposed Law (Developmental): The hearing faculty develops through intentional practice according to a five-stage affective progression (Receiving → Responding → Valuing → Organization → Characterization). The critical transition is from Level 2 to Level 3 — from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation. This same progression applies to small groups as collectives, not just to individuals. The practices in this exploration (Any Doubts?, Garden of Your Heart, PROAPT) are specifically targeted at supporting the transitions between levels. Progress is spiral, not linear; suffering is a potential engine of depth, not just an obstacle.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The developmental claim — that hearing improves with practice — is confirmed by observation and consistent with the Vol 1 obedience channel law. The specific effectiveness of each exercise varies by person and context; the Any Doubts? process and Garden of Your Heart are the highest-confidence tools from my direct observation. The five-level taxonomy is adapted from doctoral research in Christian education using the Affective Taxonomy (Krathwohl et al., 1964) applied to spiritual formation.*

VOL 3 CONNECTION: The Affective Taxonomy formal map developed here serves as Vol 3's main measurement protocol for operationalizing spiritual distance (Vol 3, Exp. 4). The five observable behavioral indicators—Receiving, Responding, Valuing, Organization, Characterization—are currently the most practical method for translating the abstract concept of "spiritual distance" into testable data across a congregation. The PROAPT-based assessment protocol mentioned here is the instrument Vol 3 proposes for conducting that research.

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: This law and the MSFIG paper describe the same five-stage progression from two different perspectives — this law from within the IJH investigation, MSFIG from an external viewpoint through the Affective Taxonomy literature.

The critical transition from Level 2 to Level 3, as named in this law, is the move MSFIG calls the shift from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation — from practicing because an accountability structure mandates it to practicing because the payoff is personally experienced. MSFIG identifies this as the most significant and challenging threshold in the entire taxonomy, emphasizing that the Holy Spirit's convicting work is essential at each level transition — it cannot be solely engineered by curriculum design. The three exercises outlined in this Exploration are specifically designed to foster conditions for the Spirit's work during the Level 2 to Level 3 transition. HFT provides a detailed explanation of how the PROAPT method sequentially targets each affective level within a single small group session.

The architectural move this section makes — mapping the hearing journey onto a formal five-stage taxonomy — is the operationalization of a proposal first laid down in the Theological Anthropology paper (TA). TA argues that because the heart, soul, and spirit are scripturally distinct faculties with different developmental logics, Bloom's Taxonomy (which covers only the mind) needs parallel taxonomies for each of the other three. TA calls this a natural next step and leaves the work to follow-up research; HFT, SST, and what is done in this Exploration are that follow-up. Read in TA's light, the five levels named here are not just a convenient scaffold for hearing — they are one of the three missing parallel taxonomies TA proposed, with a specific scriptural test case (trust in scripture under the Parable of the Sower). The practical implication: a facilitator using this five-level map is also, whether they know it or not, using the tool TA argued the field needed but did not yet have. TA sits first among the five Formation Documents in Vol 5 because it is where that need was first articulated.

PART III

Sustaining: Community, Practice, and the Long Game

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 7A — COMPANION COMPETENCY LAW

Seventh Exploration (A): Discernment of Voices as Level II Companion Competency

Why This Has To Be Named Before the Voice-Work Protocols

Exploration 7 named the hearing faculty as a skill that develops through specific practices, and opened with a doctrinal frame naming the canonical boundary inside which all the hearing work in this volume operates: the Spirit speaks today, but what the Spirit says is the application of canonical truth to the specific moment, never new canonical revelation. The discernment-of-voices work below operates inside that same boundary — the Spirit-conviction this discipline helps identify is the Spirit's application of revealed truth to the participant in the moment, never new revelation that adds to or alters what scripture has already established. This Exploration names a discipline that has to be in place *before* any of the voice-work protocols (the shame-voice work in A8, the empty-chair work in A3, the figure-speech work in B11, the somatic-voice work in B14, the localized-trauma speech work in B15, the spiritual-quadrant discernment in B17, the steps 2 and 4 discernment in B18, the contract-naming work in A25) can be safely deployed. The discipline is the discernment of *what kind of voice* is operating in the moment of the work.

There are at minimum three distinct kinds of voice the Companion encounters in formation work, and each requires a different response. **First**, *Spirit-conviction* (John 16:8). The Spirit convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment. The response when this voice is operating is *obedience*, not protocol-based transformation. A Companion who treats a Spirit-conviction as a wound to be cleared has transformed what should be obeyed; the participant is left further from the obedience the Spirit was inviting them into. **Second**, *accusation* (Revelation 12:10). The accuser of the brethren accuses them day and night. The response when this voice is operating is *resistance*, on the basis of the standing identity in Christ (Romans 8:1). A Companion who treats an accusation as a Spirit-conviction calls the participant to confess what scripture has already declared in the negative; the participant is left negotiating on the accuser's terms. **Third**, an *internalized lie* or *remembered parental voice*. This is the territory the voice-work protocols actually address — the lie at the root (Exploration 3), the false-self verdict (Exploration 2A), the contract-message (Exploration 2C). The response when this voice is operating is therapeutic engagement through the relevant tool family.

The Companion's discernment of which kind of voice is operating is a Level II competency. Protocols deployed without this discernment produce real damage — they transform what should be obeyed, engage what should be resisted, or fail to address what was actually a lie.

How This Sits With the Refined Container Discipline

This Exploration is paired with the witness-discipline (refined Exploration 8 paragraph 3 below): the Companion *discerns* the voice's kind and *witnesses* the participant's engagement with it. Both disciplines operate in the same Companion moment. Discernment without witness becomes a Companion-led interpretation that forecloses on the formation work; witness without discernment becomes presence without protection. The two together — discerning *which* voice is operating and

witnessing *the participant's* engagement with it — are the canonical Companion-II competency for voice-engaging protocols.

Proposed Law (Companion Competency): Formation work involving internal voices presupposes a prior discernment of the voice's kind. Spirit-conviction (John 16:8) is heeded; the response is obedience, not protocol-based transformation. Accusation (Revelation 12:10) is resisted; the response is the standing identity in Christ (Romans 8:1), not negotiation on the accuser's terms. Internalized lie or remembered parental voice is addressed therapeutically through the relevant tool family. The Companion's discernment of which kind of voice is operating is a Level II competency, and protocols deployed without this discernment produce real damage — they transform what should be obeyed, engage what should be resisted, or fail to address what was actually a lie.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *Directly stated in scripture across four texts (1 John 4:1 for the testing discipline; John 16:8 for Spirit-conviction; Rev 12:10 for accusation; Rom 8:1 for the standing-in-Christ identity). Operational pattern across decades of practice. Convergent across all four streams of the tradition. The Phase 2 work on A8 named the discernment step as non-optional at the front of the protocol; the May 11, 2026 Council Batch 1 acceptance (Claim 11) elevated this from bookkeeping flag to registry-level canonical claim. Among the most operationally consequential moves in the Phase 2 program.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V1.Exp1; V1 §1.3 (A Note on the Inclusion Criteria, refined in v5_6_0_14 — the Spirit's witness operates through and in confirmation of scripture, not as an independent epistemic source; the discernment work below sits inside that canonical boundary); V1.FL.VI (Hear-and-Obey Blessing — sibling to the Obedience Channel: same antecedent of hearing-plus-doing, different consequent of flourishing rather than more revelation); V2.Exp4; V2.Exp7 (the Doctrinal Frame Before the Practices added in v5_6_0_9 supplies the canonical boundary this Exploration's discernment work extends). Downstream: V2.Exp6; V2.Exp6C; V2.Exp2A; V2.Exp3. Canonical instances in Vol 5 Part VI: A24 Blessing Receiving with God-split, A25 Breaking the Contracts, A8 (originating-instance), A23 BoB Shadow and Projections, B11, B14, B15, B17, B18.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 8 — STRUCTURAL

Eighth Exploration: The Container — Preparing the Conditions for Hearing in the Community



What a Container Is

The container is the prepared interior space that a group of men or women creates together before doing any significant spiritual work. We call it a container because it is like a vessel — it holds what happens inside it, creates a boundary between the sacred work and the ordinary noise of life, and provides the structural conditions for genuine encounter. It is not a magic circle or a ritual formula. It is a set of relational commitments that, when genuinely entered into, change the quality of what can happen inside them.

Let me tell you how Dave Smith describes opening one of these containers, because the theory is only half of it. The other half is the room.

We would start standing in a circle — everyone on their feet, which matters more than it sounds. Standing brings a different kind of energy than slouching on a couch. Someone holds a walking stick in the center, and every man puts one hand on it. That physical point of contact does something I still can't fully explain — it creates a shared focus before anyone has said a word. We open with short prayers, inviting the Holy Spirit in, and then we move to the first real question: “What are you feeling right now?” Not “how are you doing,” which gets you “fine.” Feeling. And the practice is to name the emotion — glad, angry, sad, afraid, ashamed — and maybe say a sentence about it. That's it. No stories yet, no explanations. Just where you actually are in this moment.

From there, each man has the option to “put out” something that might block his presence — the argument he had in the car, the deadline sitting on his chest — by naming it and physically gesturing it out. And then to “bring in” a blessing or an intention. These are short, strong, and real.

Finally, before any work begins, each man makes eye contact with every other man in the circle — five to ten seconds each — and asks himself silently: Can I share my heart with this man tonight? Am I safe here? Can I give to him and receive from him? If the answer is yes for everyone, you say, “I'm clear.” If it isn't, you say so, and you deal with it before going further. What Dave calls man-to-man clearing — working through an actual conflict or residue between two men, in front of the group, using a facilitator — is one of the most powerful things I've seen in a group setting. The container cannot hold genuine work if there is unaddressed static between its members.

None of this is ritual for its own sake. Each step maps directly onto the four conditions above. The emotional check-in moves you from your head into the present — it is the embodied practice of the Presence condition. Putting out and bringing in clears the channel. The eye contact surfaces anything

in the way of the Safety and Clarity conditions before the work starts. When all four conditions are genuinely in place, what happens next is often surprising, and almost always good.

The four conditions of a genuine container are Safe (includes confidential), Present, Clear, and Intentional. I want to connect each of these to the spiritual laws they implement.

Safe: The Hearing Condition

Rom. 14:3-4 (ESV)

"Let not the one who eats despise the one who abstains, and let not the one who abstains pass judgment on the one who eats, for God has welcomed him. Who are you to pass judgment on the servant of another? It is before his own master that he stands or falls."

Safety in a container is not the absence of challenge; it is the assurance that I will not be judged as a person while I am doing my work. I can say what is actually true about my interior life without the fear that what I reveal will be used against me or published outside the container. This is the condition that makes genuine sharing — and therefore genuine hearing — possible. A person who is managing the risk of exposure cannot simultaneously be open to the Spirit. The two orientations are mutually exclusive in the moment.

Present: The Attention Condition

Rev. 1:8 (ESV)

"I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, 'who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty.'"

Presence is the act of bringing my full attention into this specific moment, with these specific people, in the awareness that the Great I AM is present here. The practice of naming my current emotional state at the start of a container is a simple but effective technique for moving from conceptual presence ("I know I should be here") to actual presence ("here is what is actually happening inside me right now"). The naming anchors me in the present rather than in my thoughts about the past or future.

Clear: The Channel Condition

Matt. 7:5 (ESV)

"You hypocrite, first take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother's eye."

Being clear means I have no conscious barrier between myself and God, and no unaddressed issue between myself and the other men. The log metaphor is relevant: if I am carrying an unacknowledged judgment of another person in the group, my hearing in that group is degraded. I am perceiving through the log rather than seeing clearly. The clearing process is simple: before the work begins, I identify anything that is between my God and me, or between another person and me, and I address it. I do not need to process it fully; I need to acknowledge it and set it aside so it does not occupy my attention during work.

Intentional: The Obedience Condition

John 5:19 (ESV)

"So Jesus said to them, 'Truly, truly, I say to you, the Son can do nothing of his own accord, but only what he sees the Father doing. For whatever the Father does, that the Son does likewise.'"

This is Jesus' own description of the intentional posture. He did not come into a room with an agenda; He came with eyes open to what the Father was already doing. Intentionality in a container

is that same advanced declaration: I am here, I am watching, I am willing to do whatever you show me, regardless of whether I had it in my plan. A man who enters a container with conditions on his obedience — “I will do whatever God asks as long as it is not this specific thing” — has not actually entered the container. He is still outside it, negotiating.

Proposed Law (Structural): The container — the set of relational conditions (Safe, Present, Clear, Intentional) established before community spiritual work — is the practical implementation of the Vol 1 hearing channel law in a group context. Each condition removes a specific class of interference: Safety removes the fear of exposure; Presence removes the distraction of past and future; Clarity removes the degrading effect of unacknowledged judgment; Intentionality opens the obedience channel in advance. When all four conditions are genuinely in place, the group’s collective hearing capacity is significantly greater than the sum of individual capacities.

The container is itself formative, not merely instrumental. The four conditions enable the work; the formally marked opening and the formally marked closing are themselves acts of formation. The closing of the container — the de-roling, the affirmation grounded in what the Spirit spoke, the formal release of role-players — is the move that determines what the participant carries out into the rest of their life. Work that is opened but not closed, or closed sloppily, dissipates rather than integrates. Companions are responsible for the marked-ness of both moments.

The Companion's role in receiving disclosure within the container — whether confession, lament, anger-naming, empty-chair speech, blessing reception, contract-breaking, or other formation work where the participant names something into the room — is *witness* rather than *reframing*. The naming itself is the formative act; the Companion's discipline is to hold the room while the naming happens, to offer the Lord's presence rather than the Companion's interpretation, and to defer any pastoral redirection to a subsequent conversation. The Christian instinct to fix or absolve immediately is a failure mode; foreclosing on the disclosure interrupts the work the Spirit is doing in the naming. The witness-discipline does not preclude later pastoral counsel — it preserves the formation moment so the later counsel has a true thing to address. This is part of what makes the container *Present* and *Clear*: the Companion is fully attending in the moment without supplying interpretation, and the room is kept free of the foreclosing comfort that would close what the disclosure opened.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The four conditions are well-established from practice. The claim that collective hearing exceeds the sum of individual hearing is consistent with the NT model of communal discernment (Acts 13, 1 Cor 14) and with direct observation in groups that have achieved all four conditions. The formally-marked-opening-and-closing refinement (Council Batch 1, accepted May 11, 2026) makes explicit what the de-roling and closing-affirmation work has long depended on. The witness-discipline refinement (Council Batch 2, Claim 10, accepted May 12, 2026) names a Companion competency that has been operating across the corpus's disclosure work but was previously named only in A6 Phase 2 bookkeeping; stating it as canonical V2 material gives the discipline a registry home and a teachable name. Open question carried forward: a Powlison-lineage refinement clause distinguishing immediate-redirection cases (genuine emergency, clear category error) from the default witness-discipline cases is preserved at the Vol 5 Companion paper's practitioner-level treatment; may be added to canonical text in a future Council action if raised.*

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: The four container conditions (Safe, Present, Clear, Intentional) represent the small-group implementation of what MSFIG describes as the conditions for corporate hearing and obedience at Levels 3–5. MSFIG’s small group taxonomy explains that Level 3 is when trust enables the group to shift from discussing God’s Word to

discerning God's voice together — and each of the four container conditions directly tackles a specific obstacle to that transition. Safety removes the fear of exposure that keeps people at Level 2 (performing for approval). Presence removes distractions from the past and future that prevent genuine attention to the Spirit's movement. Clarity eliminates the degrading effect of unacknowledged judgment that turns discernment into performance. Intentionality acts as the group's equivalent of the Vol 1 obedience channel — opening the hearing channel in advance by choosing to obey before knowing the details of the prompting.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 8B — STRUCTURAL-OPERATIONAL CLAIM

Eighth Exploration (B): The Session Liturgy

What This Volume Has Been Missing

For many years the corpus has named the pieces of the work — the four connects, the container, the clearings, the hearing-with-understanding, the community amplification, the corporate witness, the tool map, the import discipline — without naming explicitly the thing the pieces compose into. The thing is a *session*: a gathered time when a group meets to do this work together. The pieces are not items on a checklist; they are sequenced moves within one practice — one liturgy — and the integrity of the sequence is what makes the work the work. The May 2026 Phase 2 work on B16 (the Session Liturgy) and the synthesis pass that followed it surfaced this as a canonical claim in its own right, sitting as a compound-claim companion to Exploration 8's container claim.

The session has been operationally practiced in Band of Brothers and Fellowship of the Heart bodies since at least February 2004 (TGL's Band of Brothers Group Session Protocol is the earliest written form I know of) and in the *Field Manual: How to Start and Sustain a God-Focused Men's Small Group* (Tittle with Smith, 2008) as the practitioner-level operational depth. The 2004 protocol named what the practice has carried for decades, and the 2008 *Field Manual* gave the practitioner-level depth. What was missing until 2026 was the canonical-claim altitude statement of what the session *is*.

The Components of a Session

A session has front-notes (orientation to what the work is and who is doing it); a formally-marked opening that establishes the container in the sense of Exploration 8; clearings that surface and address what would interfere with the work (PIES is the canonical clearing-method here — Exploration 8B's clearing sub-component is treated at depth in Vol 5 Part VI's B17 entry); the work itself, which the Companion has discerned for *this* gathering from the corpus's menu (a tool from Exploration 6's Map, a hearing exercise from Exploration 7, an Exploration 2/2A/2B/2C diagnostic move, a connection-work move from Exploration 5, the specific protocol the Companion has discerned the gathering needs); the formally-marked closing that integrates the work into life (the de-roling work, the closing affirmation, the marked release); and the teachings the body has learned to receive at the close.

Three points about this composition. **First**, the items are not optional checklist elements. They are sequenced moves within one practice. The opening without the work is empty ritual; the work without the closing dissipates; the closing without the opening floats. The integrity of the sequence is what makes the work the work. **Second**, the session is the Lord's. We are gathered in His name; the Spirit is among us; we are receiving the work the Lord is doing in the gathered body. The Companion's job is not to lead the work but to hold the liturgy that lets the Lord do the work He is doing. **Third**, the session liturgy is canonical home for community formation work in the corpus's practice — the place where the Tool Map (Exploration 6), the Container discipline (Exploration 8), the Community-as-Amplifier work (Exploration 9), and the Tool Import Discipline (Exploration 0) come together into one practice that is more than the sum of its parts.

The Christian tradition has names for this practice from its own resources — Acts 2:42–47's apostolic gathering pattern; Acts 13:1–3's ministering-to-the-Lord-and-fasting pattern; 1 Corinthians 14:26–33's orderly-gathering pattern; Matthew 18:18–20's gathered-in-the-name authority; Hebrews 10:23–25's assembling discipline; Acts 20:7–12's table-and-word pattern; Luke 24:13–35's Emmaus road master pattern. The Pietist conventicle lineage (Spener's *Pia Desideria*, 1675; Francke's

Hallesche Berichte; Wesley's class meetings; Bonhoeffer's *Life Together*, 1939; Peterson's *Working the Angles*, 1987; James K. A. Smith's *Desiring the Kingdom*, 2009) names the same pattern at different historical moments. The corpus's session liturgy stands in this lineage.

Proposed Law (Structural-Operational): The work the rest of Vol 2 names — the four-connects, the container, the clearings, the hearing-with-understanding, the community amplification, the corporate witness, the tool map, the import discipline — does not happen in pieces. It happens in sessions. A session is the gathered time when a group meets to do this work together: the front-notes that orient us to what the work is and who is doing it; the formally-marked opening that establishes the container; the clearings that surface and address what would interfere with the work; the work itself, which the Companion has discerned for this gathering from the corpus's menu; the formally-marked closing that integrates the work into life; the teachings that the body has learned to receive at the close. These are not optional checklist items. They are sequenced moves within one practice — one liturgy — and the integrity of the sequence is what makes the work the work. The session liturgy is canonical home for community formation work in the corpus's practice. The session is the Lord's; we are gathered in His name; the Spirit is among us; we are receiving the work the Lord is doing in the gathered body.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *The session-as-a-whole has been operationally practiced in BoB / FotH bodies since at least Feb 2004 (TGL Feb 2004 Session Protocol as earliest written form); the operational confidence is high. The Clearly Taught reflects the practice's long operational history balanced against the V2-canonical-text-altitude canonization being recent (Cycle 3, May 12, 2026; compound-claim with V2.Exp8 refined per the compound-claim naming convention established at V2.Exp6A + V2.Exp6B). The canonization closes the session-as-a-whole gap identified as the single most important finding of the BoB-source Phase 1 work.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V2.Exp8 (the paired container claim — V2.Exp8B is its compound-claim companion); V2.Exp0; V2.Exp5; V2.Exp6; V2.Exp7; V2.Exp9; V2.Exp10. Operational depth: Vol 5 Part VI entry for B16 (Session Liturgy) and B17 (PIES — the canonical clearings sub-component); *Field Manual* (Tittle with Smith, 2008) for practitioner-level operational depth.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 9 — STRUCTURAL AND OPERATIONAL

Ninth Exploration: Community as Amplifier — The Law and the Danger

The Positive Case

I have been saying throughout this volume that the spiritual journey requires community. I want to now state this as a formal law and ground it properly, because it is one of the most counter-cultural claims in the entire IJH project. In a culture that prizes individual spiritual experience and private relationship with God, the claim that genuine community is structurally required — not merely helpful — for full spiritual operation will be resisted.

Acts 13:2 (ESV)

"While they were worshiping the Lord and fasting, the Holy Spirit said, 'Set apart for me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.'"

The Holy Spirit spoke into a community assembled, worshiping, fasting, and submitted together. The call to Saul and Barnabas was communally discerned before it was individually sent out. This is the designed operating mode of the church for significant spiritual direction. Not that God never speaks to individuals alone — He clearly does. But the call to a major mission was confirmed through the community, and the sending was from the community. That pattern is not accidental.

1 Cor. 14:29 (ESV)

"Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh what is said."

The community tests what is heard. The testing is not skepticism; it is the correction mechanism that keeps the individual's hearing honest. In a healthy community, my word that does not ring true to the others does not simply get suppressed — it is examined. If the others are genuinely submitted to the Spirit and not merely to their own preferences, their resistance is information. It may be wrong — the Jeremiah/Noah exception exists and is real — but it deserves weight, not dismissal. Proverbs reinforces this from both angles: "Where there is no guidance, a people falls, but in an abundance of counselors there is safety" (Prov. 11:14 ESV), and "Iron sharpens iron, and one man sharpens another" (Prov. 27:17 ESV). These are not merely social observations; in the IJH framework, they describe a structural feature of how the Spirit works — the community amplification loop requires friction to produce clarity, not just agreement.

Before a community can do any of that, it has to become one. That sounds obvious, but in practice, it is the step most groups skip — and skipping it is one of the primary reasons groups plateau at Level 2 in the hearing taxonomy, doing good things but never getting to the depth where genuine communal discernment becomes possible.

What Dave Smith and I found in our Band of Brothers work is that the most powerful thing a group can do in its early formative meeting is ask every man two questions: What do you want from this group? And what are you willing to give? You write the answers down. You look for what's common. And you build a simple, plain-language agreement — a social contract — out of the common ground. Not a formal document. A living commitment that you revisit every few months and hold each other to.

The social contract does something precise in the IJH framework. It operationalizes the Intentional condition from the container into a group commitment, not just an individual one. It means the community has, before it did any heart work, answered the question: Why are we here, and what are we willing to become? That decision, made together and in the open, is what allows a group to move

from social fellowship — which is good — to something that can actually test what individual members hear and help them carry it forward.

A community that has never answered those questions together is still a collection of individuals. A community that has answered them — and keeps answering them as the group changes and grows — is beginning to become something with structural integrity. That integrity is what makes the amplification possible. It is also what the Gnostic danger attacks first, which is why what comes next matters so much.

The Gnostic Community Danger — And Its Resolution

A gnostic community is one that has closed its feedback loop. It treats its own internal consensus as self-validating — "we all heard the same thing, so it must be right." It has stopped submitting what it hears to external testing. It has become a closed system that amplifies whatever signal and messages are already present inside it, whether that signal is from the Spirit or not. The history of the church has many examples of communities that started with genuine spiritual hunger and ended in isolation, error, and harm, and the mechanism is almost always the same: the feedback loop is closed.

There is an active agent in this drift, not just a passive sociological tendency. The Adversary has every reason to drive a community toward closed-loop self-validation: a community that has stopped testing what it hears cannot be corrected, and a community that cannot be corrected can be slowly steered. The tactics are recognizable in any community I have watched drift this way. Flattery directed at the insiders: you are the ones who really get it; the others outside don't. Contempt directed at the outsiders: they don't understand, they aren't really walking in the Spirit, they wouldn't get it. The slow elevation of a single voice (often a charismatic leader) above genuine testing. The increasing internal certainty about ever-more-specific claims. The discomfort with anyone who raises a question becoming, over time, the assumption that anyone who raises a question is opposing the Spirit. Paul names the broad pattern with the most precision: "such men are false apostles, deceitful workmen, disguising themselves as apostles of Christ. And no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light. So it is no surprise if his servants, also, disguise themselves as servants of righteousness" (2 Cor. 11:13–15, ESV). Each tactic taken alone is plausible. Together, they are the operational form of the feedback-loop closure. The enemy does not need to attack the community with a dramatic temptation; he only needs to whisper you are the ones repeatedly, and over time the community starts to believe it. See V2.Exp2B for the load-bearing account of the Adversary's role in the corpus; the three resolution conditions named below — submission to the Word, openness to external correction, observable fruit — are the operational counter to this drift.

The three conditions that keep a community open are:

1. Submission to the written Word as the external reference. What the community hears must be consistent with what the scriptures say. Not just consistent with individual proof-texts pulled out of context, but consistent with the full witness of scripture read carefully and honestly. The Word is outside the community and prior to it; it cannot be revised by what the community hears.
2. Genuine openness to correction from outside the group. If the community is unwilling to hear from people outside its own circle, it has closed its feedback loop. This does not mean every outside voice carries equal weight. But the posture of genuine openness must be maintained, or the correction mechanism is broken.
3. Observable fruit in the natural world as the final test. Derek Prince's test is the right one: wisdom that comes through the Holy Spirit produces miracles; if it does not, it is human wisdom. More broadly: does what the community hears and acts on produce results in the

lives of people that are consistent with the character and purposes of God? Is it drawing people to Christ or away from Him? Is it producing the fruit of the Spirit or the fruit of the flesh in the lives of the members? The fruit is a final piece of evidence.

The Prophetic Exception — Properly Bounded

Jeremiah stood alone against the false prophets and was right. Noah stood against the entire pre-flood world and was right. These exceptions are real and cannot be dismissed. The IJH project itself started with one man and a few guys in a living room on Saturday mornings, when the wider religious community showed no interest. I have had to stand on convictions that were not confirmed by the community around me.

But there is a difference between Jeremiah's position and simple stubbornness. Jeremiah had a specific, verifiable, scripturally-grounded word. He could point to it. He held it before the community for testing. He did not simply assert that he was right because he felt strongly. And the word was eventually vindicated in the natural — the event happened as he said it would.

The standard for standing alone against community consensus: a specific, verifiable, scripturally-grounded word, held up for testing (not asserted against testing), and patient enough to wait for the natural vindicating event. This is a high bar. It should be a high bar. In most situations where I think I am Jeremiah, I am actually just someone who does not like being corrected.

Jer. 1:17-19 (ESV)

"But you, dress yourself for work; arise, and say to them everything that I command you. Do not be dismayed by them, lest I dismay you before them... They will fight against you, but they shall not prevail against you, for I am with you, declares the Lord, to deliver you."

Even the genuine prophet standing alone is not standing alone. The strength to stand comes from the Lord, not from self-confidence. And the willingness to stand is accompanied by the willingness to be tested and vindicated by events, not by insistence on being believed immediately.

Proposed Law (Structural and Operational): Genuine spiritual community amplifies hearing, multiplies faith, and provides the correction mechanism that keeps individual discernment honest. The amplification effect requires all four container conditions (Exploration 8) plus three openness conditions: submission to the written Word, genuine openness to external correction, and observable fruit as the final test. A community that closes its feedback loop by treating internal consensus as self-validating becomes a gnostic community — amplifying and embracing error as readily as truth. The prophetic exception (standing alone against community consensus) is valid only when the standard is fully met: specific, verifiable, scripturally-grounded, patient, held for testing, and ultimately vindicated in the natural realm.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The positive case for community amplification is strong (Acts 13, 1 Cor 14, and consistent with my experience). The gnostic community mechanism is well-documented in church history. The prophetic exception standard is my working formulation — held at about Speculative — and needs broader community input.*

VOL 3 CONNECTION: The Community Amplification law described here is formalized in Vol 3 as one of the three primary feedback loops in the spiritual dynamics model (Vol 3, Exp. 7). Vol 3's Community Amplification Reinforcing Loop represents the positive case: genuine community enhances hearing and multiplies faith as a reinforcing loop, rather than merely adding effects. The gnostic community warning — that a closed feedback loop can amplify error as easily as truth — is modeled in Vol 3 as a second-order instability in the resonance system.

FORMATION DOCUMENT CONNECTION: MSFIG's small group taxonomy outlines the development of community amplification at each affective level — and what happens when it breaks down. At Level 2, the community does not yet amplify: the leader teaches and members listen, prayer is informational, and the Spirit's distribution across multiple members is not yet accessed. The amplification described by this law begins at Level 3, where trust fosters corporate discernment, and reaches its key expression at Level 5, where former members lead new groups with the same culture — not by following a manual, but by being formed by the original group. The gnostic community warning in this law (a closed feedback loop amplifies error as easily as truth) aligns exactly with MSFIG's observation that Level 5 culture is portable but can only be transmitted by someone who has been there — meaning a community led by someone who has not reached Level 3+ and has closed its feedback loop to external correction is in precisely the error-amplifying condition this law warns about.

One specific mechanism of community amplification is worth naming on its own, because it operates invisibly and people who haven't been in a genuine Band of Brothers tend to underestimate it until they've been inside one. Dave Smith calls it co-processing.

When one man is working a process in the group — moving through a fear knot, confronting a vow, exaggerating a doubt in the Any Doubts exercise — every other man in the room is doing the same work silently. Not observing. Not waiting for their turn. Working. The questions the facilitator is asking one man aloud are landing in every other man's interior at the same time. The emotional charge the man is moving through is resonating in each of them. This parallel, interior work is co-processing, and its effects on the group are often as significant as the effects on the man who is working out loud.

I have seen this too many times to attribute it to coincidence. The man who says nothing and does nothing visible in a session can come away having done as much interior work as the man who stood in the circle. Sometimes more, because he had the freedom to go wherever the Spirit was taking him without the external structure constraining the direction. This is also why the container conditions matter for everyone in the room, not just the man who is processing — a man who is emotionally defended, checked out, or privately judging the man working cannot co-process. He is outside the container while physically inside it.

Co-processing is one reason a well-run group session produces fruit across the whole group, not just in the man whose work was on the agenda. It is also a strong argument for doing the deep work in community rather than alone. The resonance is not available in a private session with a counselor, and it is not available in a group that is only sharing information. It requires the combination of genuine safety, a man willing to work openly, and others willing to let that work touch them. When all three are present, something happens in the room that is genuinely greater than the sum of its parts.

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 9A — DEVELOPMENTAL LAW

Ninth Exploration (A): The Corporate Witness of Declared Identity

Where the Authority Comes From

Several of the corpus's closing-affirmation and group-amplification protocols produce *I am* statements at moments of peak emotional release — at the close of a clearing, in a blessing round, in a corporate-mission declaration, in a renunciation-and-receiving sequence. The Phase 2 work on A13 (Affirmation with Win-Win Group Amplification) named the move explicitly; A16, A24, and several of the Cycle 1 and Cycle 2 protocols deploy versions of it. The move works because the group amplifies what is declared — voices joining the declared identity, witnesses confirming it, the body itself acting as the corporate validator of what was named.

This Exploration names the underlying claim about *where the authority of those statements comes from*. The biblical pattern is clear and uniform: Christian identity is *given* before it is enacted, *declared by God* before it is declared by the person, and *corporately witnessed* rather than self-generated. Mark 1:11 is the master pattern — the Father declares the Son's identity before the Son enacts the ministry; the declaration is the foundation, not the result, of what follows. Romans 8:16 — the Spirit bears witness with our spirit — names the operational form: the corporate witness is the Spirit-and-our-spirit pattern, not a self-assertion the group amplifies. 1 Peter 2:9–10 — *you are a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for his own possession* — is the corporate identity declared by God and received by the community. Revelation 2:17 — *to the one who conquers I will give ... a new name* — names the eschatological completion of the same pattern.

The Adversary at the Moment of Declared Identity

The same biblical pattern that establishes the corporate-witness-of-declared-identity move also names what comes immediately after it: opposition. Mark 1:11 (ESV) — “You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased” — is followed immediately by Mark 1:12–13: “The Spirit immediately drove him out into the wilderness. And he was in the wilderness forty days, being tempted by Satan.” Matthew's account makes the form of the temptation explicit. The enemy's first words to Jesus in the wilderness were not new accusations; they were a direct attack on the identity the Father had just declared: “If you are the Son of God...” (Matt. 4:3, 6, ESV). The pattern is universal. The declared identity is the moment of greatest authority and the moment of most precise attack. The serpent's tactic at the Jordan was identical to his tactic in the garden — putting an if under what God had said.

Participants doing the declared-identity work in this corpus will encounter the same pattern. The moment of corporate declaration is followed by a counter-voice within the next hours or days: “You're not really that.” “Look at what you did last week.” “This won't last.” “Who are you to claim this?” These are recognizable as the same voice that met Jesus in the wilderness. They are not the participant's own honest doubts; they are accusation in the technical sense (Rev. 12:10 ESV — “the accuser of our brothers, who accuses them day and night before our God”).

What the corporate witness does, beyond what was named above, is operate as the standing memory of the declared identity against the accusation that will come. The body holds what was declared so the participant does not have to face the accuser alone. This is part of why the corporate witness must be embodied — names spoken aloud, voices joining, witnesses confirming — rather than merely individual or private. The accuser operates against the isolated; the body operates against the isolation. The discernment-of-voices discipline named in Exploration 7A applies here directly: the

accusation is to be resisted, on the basis of the declared identity (Rom. 8:1, 33–34 ESV: “There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus... Who shall bring any charge against God’s elect? It is God who justifies. Who is to condemn?”). Companions preparing participants for declared-identity work should also prepare them for the accusation that follows it, so the participant is not surprised by the pattern. See V2.Exp2B for the load-bearing account of the Adversary’s role in the corpus.

The Critical Distinction

The corporate amplification of *declared* identity is biblical practice. The corporate amplification of *self-generated* identity is not. The difference is what the Companion attends to at the close of any work that produces an *I am* statement. The Companion’s question at the close is *what did the Lord speak in this?* — not *what do you want to claim about yourself?* The corporate witness amplifies the first kind of statement; it does not amplify the second. When the group amplifies the first kind, the body is operating as the Spirit-bearing-witness pattern of Romans 8:16. When the group amplifies the second kind, the body is operating as a self-affirmation circle, which the New Testament does not commend and which produces a different kind of work entirely.

This is the locus reversal the A13 Phase 2 work made explicit — Spirit-source vs. participant-self-source — and which the May 11, 2026 Council Batch 1 acceptance (Claim 2) gave registry-level canonical name. The Companion’s discipline at the closing affirmation is to ground the affirmation in what the Spirit spoke or what scripture declares, and the corporate amplification follows the Amen pattern of 1 Corinthians 14:16 — confirming what was given, not generating what was claimed.

Proposed Law (Developmental): Christian identity is given before it is enacted, declared by God before it is declared by the person, and corporately witnessed rather than self-generated. Formation work that produces *I am* statements — at moments of peak emotional release, in closing affirmations, in group acclamation — derives the authority of those statements from what God has spoken or what scripture declares, not from the participant’s self-assertion. The corporate amplification of declared identity (the Amen pattern; the Spirit-bearing-witness pattern of Romans 8:16) is biblical practice; the corporate amplification of self-generated identity is not.

Certainty: Clearly Taught *Directly stated in scripture (Mark 1:11, Rom 8:16, 1 Pet 2:9–10, Rev 2:17) and operational pattern across decades. The Phase 2 work on A13 made the locus reversal explicit — Spirit-source vs. participant-self-source — and the May 11, 2026 Council Batch 1 acceptance (Claim 2) gives the underlying claim a registry-level name. Mild Wesleyan-Holiness emphasis on participatory agency in identity formation is acknowledged but not opposing; the Wesleyan-Holiness stream affirms the givenness side as primary.*

Cross-references. Upstream: V1.Ax1; V1.Ax2; V1.Exp1; V2.Exp8 (the container’s marked closing is where the corporate witness happens). Downstream: V2.Exp8B; V2.Exp9; V2.Exp10. Canonical instances in Vol 5 Part VI: A13 (originating instance), A16 (corporate mission), A21 (embodied resonance), A24 (blessing rounds), A25 (renunciation-and-receiving sequence), B11 (figure-as-door corporate witness).

VOL 2 — EXPLORATION 10 — OPERATIONAL

Tenth Exploration: The Training Plan — Operating in Faith as a Learnable Skill



Why a Training Plan Is Not Unspiritual

There is a kind of piety that resists the idea of training, as though the Holy Spirit's gifts are too sacred to be practiced deliberately. I have come to believe this resistance is itself a subtle form of unbelief. Every human faculty that develops — musical skill, athletic ability, mathematical reasoning, surgical precision — develops through intentional, focused practice. Why would the spiritual life be different? Jesus Himself told His disciples what to do, showed them how to do it, sent them out to practice it, and debriefed them when they came back (Luke 10:1-20). That is a training sequence, not just an inspirational experience.

1 Tim. 4:7-8 (ESV)

"...train yourself for godliness; for while bodily training is of some value, godliness is of value in every way, as it holds promise for the present life and also for the life to come."

Paul uses the athletic training metaphor deliberately. Train yourself — gymnasium, the same root as gymnasium. This is intentional, repeated, progressive practice. The result, godliness, is not a state I arrive at through insight; it is a capacity I develop through training. The writer of Hebrews 12 recognizes that training is painful by using the Greek word for agony.

The Components of a Sustainable Training Plan

Based on everything I have developed in this volume, here is a starting draft of what a sustainable training plan for operating in the Laws of the Spirit might look like:

Daily: The Hearing Practice

- PROAPT scripture engagement — minimum fifteen minutes, ideally thirty. The goal is not to cover ground but to actually hear. A single verse that I genuinely hear is worth more than three chapters that I read for coverage.
- Morning attentiveness — the practice of asking, before the day begins, "Father, what are You up to today? Where will I see You? What do You want me to do or be for someone today?" And then paying attention to the answers as the day unfolds.
- Evening review — a brief backward look: Where did I see God today? Where did I miss Him? Where did I act in alignment with what I heard, and where did I not? The evening review develops the pattern recognition that the Footprints exercise trains retrospectively.

Weekly: The Community Practice

- A genuine Band of Brothers — a small group (three to eight men) who know each other's full story, who meet with a real container established, who bring real interior material to each other. Not a Bible study group that occasionally gets personal. A genuine community of hearing.
- Shared reporting — at each meeting, each man reports what he heard since the last meeting, what he acted on, and what the results were. This is the accountability structure that turns the obedience channel law from theory into practice. Knowing that I will report my hearing to the brothers next week significantly increases both the quality of my hearing and the likelihood that I will obey what I hear.

One more element of the weekly practice that I have found to be irreplaceable: how the meeting ends matters as much as how it begins.

In our Band of Brothers work, Dave Smith built a closing practice into every session. Before the container closes, each man briefly states what is happening for him right now — not a summary of what was discussed, but what he is feeling in this moment as the meeting ends. This is the same emotional check-in that opened the container, now run in reverse. It grounds the work in the body and surfaces what the session actually did for each man, which is not always what the facilitator planned.

After that, any man who has a blessing to speak over another man does so. Not a prayer for him in general — a specific, witnessed blessing: what you saw happen in that man tonight, or what the Father seemed to be saying about him during the session, spoken directly to him out loud. These are usually short. They are almost always powerful, especially for men who have rarely or never heard another man speak life over them with specificity and authority.

I want to be clear about this: I have seen grown men undone by a thirty-second blessing spoken by a brother who watched them do hard work. Not because the words were eloquent, but because they were specific, true, and given in the context of a community that had just been in the room while the work happened. That kind of blessing carries weight that general encouragement does not. It is the voice of witnessed transformation — you were here, you saw what God did, and now you are naming it back to the man it happened in. That is a spiritual function that almost nothing else in the ordinary Christian community does.

For the training plan, this means: do not let the weekly meeting end when the last process ends. End it when the last blessing has been spoken, and each man goes out carrying what his brothers saw in him that evening.

Monthly: The Clearing Practice

- A dedicated session for whatever heart maintenance is needed — which might be a GRH completion letter, a TPM session with a trusted partner, a confession to a brother, a Garden of Your Heart encounter. The frequency of monthly is a minimum; some seasons of life require more frequent clearing, particularly during periods of loss, transition, or significant spiritual warfare.
- A review of the current state of each of the Four Connects — am I genuinely connected with Self, with Others, with God, with Mission? Where is the weakest link? What does that weak link need?

Seasonally: The Deeper Work

- A retreat or extended time — a Wild at Heart Boot Camp, a contemplative retreat, an extended prayer time — that goes deeper than the regular practices can reach. Some layers of knot and soil condition are only accessible in sustained, extended time away from the ordinary demands of life.
- A review of mission clarity — am I still operating in the good works prepared for me? Has the mission shifted? What does the Spirit seem to be calling me into next?

The Training Mentor

Every serious training program requires a reference point who is further along than you are. For me, that reference point is Jesus. The most productive direction I have found for deepening the training plan is to study Jesus' ministry with the specific question: what spiritual laws is He operating in here? What is He discerning? How is He responding to what He discerns? The gospels, read through this lens, become not just an inspirational biography but an advanced textbook in the operation of the Laws of the Spirit.

I have had spiritual directors at various points in my life, and each brought me deeper into what God had for me. Spiritual direction is a lost art in the Protestant community. I have had to search hard to find one and went for years in some cases between findings. I have found Nemeck and Combs' "The Way of Spiritual Direction" to be a great reference for what it should look like and how to recognize it. Vol 5 defines a Formation Companion that integrates multiple mentoring roles that are applicable to our context. I commend that to your perusal if interested.

John 5:19 ESV: "So Jesus said to them, 'Truly, truly, I say to you, the Son can do nothing of his own accord, but only what he sees the Father doing. For whatever the Father does, that the Son does likewise.'" This is Jesus' own description of His training plan: attentive observation of the Father, immediate response to what He observes. That is the advanced version of the daily practice I described above.

Preaching and Worship as Complementary Interventions

Two corporate disciplines deserve specific attention in the training plan because they are often treated as separate activities serving separate purposes, when in fact they are designed to work together as a unit. My research in Christian education identifies them as targeting two different but complementary domains of the same hearing journey.

Preaching primarily targets the cognitive domain. Its goal is to present the Word accurately — to show who God is, what He has done, what He is doing, and what He calls us to. In terms of the Affective Taxonomy developed in Exploration 7, preaching supports Levels 1 and 2: creating awareness and inviting active engagement with the Word. It builds the mental model that frames what is of genuine value. As Harry Shields puts it, the preacher who wants to produce transformation must handle the Word carefully enough to have high confidence that what they are saying is actually what God is saying. The preacher's own formation is upstream of the congregation's.

Worship targets the affective domain. Its goal is to move the heart to desire what the mind has been shown. James Smith (2009) identifies rightly-structured worship as the primary mechanism by which people are trained to desire the Kingdom of God — not just to understand it, but to want it. In taxonomy terms, worship specifically supports the critical Level 2-to-3 transition: the shift from responding to external prompts toward intrinsically valuing what God values. The heart that has been genuinely moved in worship is more receptive to hearing at Level 3 and above.

The practical sequencing implication: preaching and worship are most effective when treated as a unit, in sequence. The Word shows what is true and worth desiring; worship is the response that

says, “I want this,” and trains the heart to mean it. A community with strong preaching but thin worship tends to produce disciples who know the right things but do not deeply desire them — Level 2 stuck. A community with emotionally powerful worship but shallow preaching tends to produce disciples who feel deeply but are not anchored to the Word — affective without cognitive grounding. Steve Lowe observes that most churches get the order wrong and start with worship before the preaching of the Word; the hearing-first principle of Exploration 1 (Rom. 10:17) suggests why the order matters.

The Adversary’s Resistance When Obedience Begins

Alongside the suffering named in the next section, there is a specific opposition the disciple meets when she actually starts doing what she has heard. Naming this is part of preparation; failing to name it leaves the disciple confused when it shows up.

The pattern is named in scripture. Paul, writing to the Thessalonians: “we wanted to come to you—I, Paul, again and again—but Satan hindered us” (1 Thess. 2:18, ESV). Daniel’s angelic messenger, delayed by twenty-one days, names the cause: “the prince of the kingdom of Persia withstood me” (Dan. 10:13, ESV). Luke’s account of Paul and Barnabas on Cyprus: “Bar-Jesus by name. He was with the proconsul... But Elymas the magician (for that is the meaning of his name) opposed them, seeking to turn the proconsul away from the faith” (Acts 13:6–8, ESV). The Adversary is operationally specific in how he resists obedience: through circumstantial obstacles, through human opposition, through internal discouragement at the moment of step-taking, through the sudden re-emergence of old patterns the disciple thought she had cleared.

The disciple who has not been told that this opposition is normal will, when it shows up, draw one of two wrong conclusions: that the obedience must not have been from God after all, or that she is failing at the work. Neither is correct. The opposition is a confirming sign, not a disconfirming sign — the enemy does not resist what is already going his way. The discipline is to name the resistance, press through it, and report it. The weekly community practice and Training Mentor components above are the operational form of this: the disciple names what she has heard, what she has done with it, and what opposition she has met. The community holds her in it, prays against the resistance, and confirms the next step. Without that reporting rhythm, the disciple is alone against the resistance. With it, she is in a body that knows what is happening and pushes back with her. This is named more fully in V2.Exp2B (the Adversary’s Role); the relevance here is operational at the training-plan altitude. The training plan assumes that opposition is constitutive of the disciple’s operating conditions, not exceptional to them.

Suffering as Engine, Not Obstacle

Any honest training plan must account for what happens when the plan is disrupted by suffering. Loss, betrayal, illness, failure, the inexplicable silence of God — these are not interruptions of the spiritual journey. In many cases, they can be a primary engine of creating increasing depth. In terms of the Sower parable, suffering might be considered fertilizer to enrich the soil for future harvest.

Walter Brueggemann’s framework for reading the Psalms identifies three phases: orientation (life is good, praise comes easily), disorientation (things have gone wrong in ways that do not make sense), and reorientation (God meets the person in the disorientation, and a deeper understanding emerges). The Psalms of Lament are addressed to God, not away from Him. The lament is itself an act of faith: I am bringing this to You because I still believe You are the One to bring it to.

Saint John of the Cross describes the Dark Night of the Soul — a period in which all the usual consolations of the spiritual life go dry. Prayer feels empty. Scripture feels flat. John’s observation: this is not punishment but the Spirit stripping away dependence on spiritual consolations so that the

faith can be rebuilt on a deeper foundation of intimate connection. The person who stays in the darkness, continues the practices, and refuses to abandon the community will emerge into a quieter and more stable relationship with God than they had before.

In terms of the Affective Taxonomy, what looks like regression during the Dark Night — a Level 4 person apparently back at Level 1, questioning everything — is often the process of moving from Level 4 to Level 5. The internalization is going deeper, not shallower. The soil is being turned more deeply so that roots can go further down. Secular research on posttraumatic growth (Tedeschi & Calhoun) confirms this pattern: the struggle with highly challenging life crises is associated with increased personal strength, changed priorities, and richer spiritual life. The taxonomy, read this way, expects a spiral path rather than a linear one.

The training plan implication: when suffering arrives, first diagnose before applying tools. Is it the consequence of sin (Confession-Restoration, Exploration 4)? A weight-consuming bandwidth (Knot-clearing, Explorations 2-3)? Or the disorientation of a deeper orientation forming — the Dark Night? The diagnostic key is whether the person is turning toward God in the suffering, even in anger or lament? Lament addressed to God is Brueggemann's disorientation, an engine. Bitterness that closes the door to God is the thorny soil choking the root, and requires the clearing tools of Part I. Applying the wrong tool to the wrong suffering will slow rather than help.

Proposed Law (Developmental): Operating in the Laws of the Spirit is a learnable skill that develops through intentional, progressive practice across three domains that must all be engaged: cognitive (understanding what is true), affective (developing genuine desire for what is true), and action (habitually doing what has been understood and desired). Preaching primarily develops the cognitive domain; worship develops the affective domain; they are most effective in sequence. The training plan suggests four timeframes (daily, weekly, monthly, seasonal) and is a system — removing any component degrades the whole. Suffering is not an interruption of the training plan but a potential engine of depth; the diagnostic is whether the suffering drives the person toward God or away from Him.

Certainty: Reasonably Inferred *The three-domain framework (cognitive, affective, and action) is supported by doctoral research applying all three of Bloom's taxonomy families to spiritual formation. The preaching-worship sequencing insight is from doctoral research in Christian education (Smith, 2009) and is consistent with the hearing-first principle of Exploration 1. The suffering-as-engine insight is consistent with Brueggemann, John of the Cross, and posttraumatic growth research. The specific timeframes remain a working proposal, not a scriptural prescription.*

Epilogue: The Invitation to Volume 3

I want to be clear about how I see the entry requirement for Volume 3.

Volume 3 is not a harder read or a more advanced intellectual framework. It is a different level of ambition entirely. Volume 1 described the laws. Volume 2 described the conditions under which a person can actually operate under those laws. Volume 3 asks what it looks like to live a life in which miracles are the normal — not the exceptional — outcome. A life in which I am beginning to quantify the spiritual forces at work, to see the equations underneath the experiences, to model the feedback systems that govern how the Spirit moves in and through my specific life.

The entry requirement for Volume 3 is not intellectual. I do not need to have understood everything in Volumes 1 and 2 theoretically. I believe I need to have experience in at least these three things:

1. The release of at least one significant emotional knot through the ministry of the Holy Spirit. Not a moment of emotional catharsis — the actual release of a knot: the valley leveling, the bandwidth returning, the old pull no longer pulling in the same way. If you have not experienced this, Part II of this volume has the tools. Start there.
2. The experience of hearing a specific word and obeying it and seeing a result in the natural. Not a vague sense of being led, but a specific word, a specific act of obedience, and a specific observable consequence. The five-for-five batting average that Larry described from those Saturday mornings. Even once is enough to change the framework.
3. The experience of genuine community correction — bringing something I thought I had heard to a group of trusted brothers and being told they did not witness it as true — and finding that the correction was right. This experience is humbling and essential. It is what teaches me to hold my hearing loosely and submit it for testing.

If you have experienced all three, you are ready for Volume 3. Not because you are spiritually advanced — but because you have moved from knowing the laws intellectually to knowing them in the way Principle 3 demands: in your spirit, in your mind and emotions, and in your body and actions. That is the foundation Volume 3 needs to build on.

If you have not experienced all three yet, that is not a failure. It is simply a description of where you are on the journey, and the journey is the point. Stay in the practices of Part III. Keep the training plan. Stay in community. Clear the knots as they surface. The experiences will come — not as rewards for performance, but as the natural fruit of a channel that is increasingly open and a heart whose soil is increasingly good.

Volume 3 is further up and further in. I will meet you there.

Blessings — Daddy and Granddaddy

